

ROYA
PUBLICATION
No. 106



WAITING FOR MY BIRD

CHEW Z

A ROYA PUBLICATION

WAITING FOR MY BIRD

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 106

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

Copyright © 2026 Chew Z

All rights reserved.

ISBN 979-8-952790-105 (provisional)

Roya Publications

Publication No. 106

Typeset in DejaVu Serif.

Printed in the Reach



THE ROOF AT FIRST LIGHT

Maidan Shahr, Wardak. Every morning before the town woke, a kaftar-baz, a pigeon player, let his flock go. They rose together, turned, flashed white, and came home to the roof they knew. Someone else was watching the roof.

SYNOPSIS

Every morning at first light, Nasim Nazari climbs to the roof of his house in Maidan Shahr, an hour west of Kabul, and lets his pigeons go. He fixes radios and telephones in the bazaar. He has a wife who sews dresses and makes up proverbs, and a daughter of eight who will not take off her pink sandals. High above the town there is a thin, patient buzzing that never goes away. Nasim believes it is looking for somebody else.

Seven and a half thousand miles away, in a cold metal trailer in the Nevada desert, Kayla Rourke works the night shift. She is a sensor operator. She points the camera of an unmanned Reaper drone, and when the order comes, she holds the laser. She has been watching a house in Wardak for forty-one days. She knows the mulberry tree, the blue door that sticks, and the man who goes up to the roof every dawn and looks straight at the sky.

She has written it down, in block capitals, so nobody can misread it: possible awareness of surveillance.

The book follows them both, through one morning that cannot be taken back and the long years after it, from a roof in Afghanistan to a casino floor in Las Vegas, where the eye in the sky is a black glass dome.

It is a story about watching, and about what happens on the day the watched man finally looks back.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book began with one phrase. The military calls it pattern of life: watching a person long enough to learn what is normal for them, so that anything strange stands out. I wanted to know what that watching does to the one who watches, and what it looks like from the roof.

Nasim, Kayla and their families are invented, as are the strike in Maidan Shahr, the casino and the man in the gray jacket. Everything around them I tried to keep true.

The rules in Kayla's chapters are the real ones. The 2013 standard of near certainty that no civilian would be hurt was real, and it did not apply in Afghanistan, which the United States counted as an area of active hostilities. In 2019, according to U.S. Air Forces Central Command, American aircraft released 7,423 weapons over Afghanistan, the most since its records began in 2006.

The strike in Kabul on 29 August 2021 is real. Ten people were killed, seven of them children. It was called a tragic mistake, and no one was punished. I took nothing from that family but the fact of it.

The question of guilt I tried not to answer. A survey of about a thousand Air Force drone operators, by psychologists at the Air Force School of Aerospace Medicine, found 4.3 percent with moderate to severe post-traumatic stress, and many proud of protecting the soldiers on the ground. The book has one of each. I do not know which is healthier.

The condolence payment is real in kind. The Pentagon reported that its payments in Afghanistan and Iraq in 2019 ranged from 169 dollars to 35,000, each one stated not to be an admission of responsibility.

The title is Nasim's. A man waiting for his bird is the most innocent thing in this book, and it is also the habit that marked him. Seen from the sky, the two look exactly the same.

Chew Z

CONTENTS

I. FORTY-ONE MORNINGS	8
II. BUGSPLAT	33
III. THE FORTIETH DAY	62
IV. DESERT INN	88
V. WHITE HOT	111

I. FORTY-ONE MORNINGS

ONE • Kayla

The war starts at six in the evening, forty-five minutes up Highway 95, and it has a parking lot.

That's the first thing nobody tells you. You think of war, you think of sand and helicopters and some poor kid from Ohio with his legs gone. You don't think of finding a space between a Silverado and a Kia Soul with a Baby On Board sticker, checking your lipstick in the mirror, and thinking, *shit, I forgot to take the chicken out.*

Creech Air Force Base sits in the desert outside a town called Indian Springs. It's where the drones are flown from. Not where they fly. The aircraft is in Afghanistan, seven and a half thousand miles away, a gray plane with no window in its nose because nobody sits in it. We sit here, in Nevada, in a box.

The Air Force calls the box a Ground Control Station. Everybody else calls it the box. It's a metal trailer with the air conditioning set to meat-locker, two chairs, a wall of screens, and a smell of burnt coffee and somebody's body spray that has been in there since the Bush administration. The pilot sits in the left chair and flies the plane. I sit in the right chair. I'm the sensor operator, which means I fly the camera. I decide what we look at. And when it's time, I hold the laser on the target, a little invisible finger of light that tells the missile where to go.

He drives. I point.

The plane is an MQ-9 Reaper, like the guy with the hood and the scythe, because somebody in the office that buys the weapons thought that was cute. It can stay up for more than a day, and it carries four Hellfire missiles under its wings like a woman carrying grocery bags. From where it circles, three miles up, it can read the shape of a man's sandal. I know this because I have read a lot of sandals.

My name is Kayla Rourke. I'm thirty-one. I have a seven-year-old son named Wyatt who believes I fly airplanes, which is true in the way most things you tell a seven-year-old are true. I have a mother in Henderson who believes I'm going to Hell, which is also probably true. I have a mouth on me. My first sergeant once told me I curse like a Navy cook with a toothache, and I told him to go fuck himself,

and he laughed, and that was the last nice thing that happened in that building.

You show your ID to a nineteen-year-old with a rifle, you put your phone in a little locker because phones aren't allowed near the war, you walk down a hallway with carpet the color of old gum, and you sit in your chair.

And then it's morning.

That's the second thing nobody tells you. Afghanistan is eleven and a half hours ahead of Las Vegas, so I leave the house in the late afternoon and walk into dawn. I have watched more sunrises over Afghanistan than over Nevada.

I've watched them in two colors. The daylight camera is just like your phone, only it's three miles up and it can count the buttons on a shirt. The other one is the infrared, the heat camera. It doesn't see light. It sees warmth. Everything warmer than the world around it glows.

You can set it two ways. Black hot, where the warm things are dark. Or white hot, where the warm things shine.

I like white hot. Most of us do. In white hot, a man is a candle walking. A cow is a lamp. An engine that ran an hour ago is a smear of milk on the road. A cup of tea held in two hands makes a little bright coin against a chest. The world is gray and cold and the living are made of light.

White means warm. Warm means alive.

They teach you that on day one, in the schoolhouse, before they teach you anything else. They teach it like a joke. It isn't a joke. It's the whole job. Everything else is just deciding which of the lights to put out.

—

The pilot was a man I'll call the pilot, because that's what he was. A captain, with a wife and three girls and a boat at Lake Mead named after his wife, which tells you most of what you need to know. He coached Little League on Saturdays. He ate the same turkey sandwich every shift with the crusts cut off, and he slept, as far as I could ever tell, like a baby in a car seat.

"Morning, sunshine," he said, which is what he said every night.

"Fuck off," I said, which is what I said every night.

There's a lag, and you should know about it now, because it matters later. The signal goes from the box to a satellite, to Europe, to another satellite, to the plane. It takes about a second and a half. You move the stick, and a second and a half later, over Afghanistan, the camera moves. You learn to live a second and a half in the future. You learn to lead everything. People say drone crews play God. We don't. God doesn't lag.

That night, the outgoing operator, a kid named Torres, handed me a house.

"New package," he said. "Wardak province. Town called Maidan Shahr."

He said it *MAY-den SHAR*. The real way is more like [mai-DAAN SHAHR], and it means the City of the Square. Wardak is [war-DAK]. I looked it all up, later. It's a provincial capital west of Kabul [KAA-bul], in a valley with mountains on both sides like a pair of hands about to clap.

"Selector's living there," Torres said.

A selector is a phone number. That's all. A string of digits that belongs to somebody somebody else wants dead. Intelligence people, a long way up from us, decide a phone belongs to a bad guy. Then they track it. Wherever the phone sleeps, we watch. People think we hunt men. Mostly we hunt phones. The men are attached.

"Facilitator," Torres said. "Moves money, moves guys. Medium fish. Phone's been sleeping in this house four nights out of the last six."

It was a house like ten thousand other houses down there. A square of mud-brick wall around a little courtyard. A tree in the courtyard. A flat roof, with stairs running up the outside. A blue metal door to the street. And on the roof, a sort of cabinet made of wire and wood.

"What's the cage," I said.

"Chickens, probably," Torres said. "They all got chickens."

That was the first day.

Here's what I want you to understand, before you hate me, which you will, and before you forgive me, which you shouldn't.

I liked the house.

I liked it the way you like a show you watch while folding laundry. I watched it twelve hours a night, which was twelve hours of their day, and I got to know it the way you know your own kitchen. I knew which corner of the courtyard got the sun first. I knew the tree was a mulberry, because in the second week the ground under it went dark and sticky with fallen fruit, and the kids from next door came and ate it off the dirt. I knew the blue door stuck, because everybody who opened it put their shoulder into it.

I knew there was a man, and a woman, and a little girl.

The man was on the roof every morning at first light. Every single morning. He opened the cage. And then he stood there on the roof, in the cold blue start of the day, with his face turned up.

Up. At the sky.

At me.

That's what I thought. God help me. That's what I wrote down.

But that comes later. The first day, all I did was what they trained me to do. I set the camera to white hot. I zoomed in until the house filled the screen. I watched three small fires moving behind its walls, a big one and a medium one and a little one, and I thought, like a prayer or a curse:

White means warm. Warm means alive.

And I started counting.

TWO • Nasim

Before the town wakes, there is a sound that comes before all other sounds, and that is the sound of the birds asking to be let out.

It is not a song. Pigeons do not sing. It is a kind of talking, low and round, made in the chest, *hoo-oo, hoo-oo*, as if the bird were a little drum struck by someone very patient. My father used to say the

pigeons talk to God before anyone else is awake, and that they only ever ask Him one question: *Is it time?*

My name is Nasim Nazari [na-SEEM na-zaa-REE]. *Nasim* means a breeze, the small cool wind that comes just before morning. My mother chose it because I was born at dawn, and she said I came into the world the way that wind comes, quietly, and wanting to be outside.

I have kept pigeons for thirty-one years. I am a *kaftar-baz* [kaf-TAR BAAZ]. The word means a pigeon player, and it is not quite a compliment. In our country, a *kaftar-baz* is a man who is up on his roof when he should be at his work, and who looks at the sky when he should be looking at his family. My wife, Laila [lay-LAA], says this about me often, and she is not wrong, and she says it smiling, and so I have never stopped.

Our house is in Maidan Shahr, in the province of Wardak, an hour's drive west of Kabul if the road is good, and three hours if the road is the road. My father built it of mud brick and timber, and I helped him by carrying water in a tin cup when I was too small to carry anything else. There is a mulberry tree in the courtyard that my mother planted the year I was born. There is a blue door to the street that has stuck since before my daughter was born, which I promise every spring to fix, and have not fixed, because a door that sticks is a door that tells you when someone is coming.

On the roof is the loft, the house of the birds. I built it with my own hands from wire and the wood of old fruit crates. It has twenty-two small rooms.

—

Let me tell you how it is done, the flying of the birds. It is the most beautiful thing I know, and I am the only one left who can tell you.

At first light I climb the outside stairs, which are cold under my feet even in summer. Below me the town is still blue, the color of milk in a dark kitchen. The mountains on either side of the valley are black, and above them the sky is the color that has no name, not yet white and no longer night. Somewhere a rooster complains. Somewhere a pot is set down on a stone.

I open the loft. First come the old ones, the ones who know the way, because they will teach the young. They sit at the edge a moment, blinking, settling their feathers, looking at the sky the way an old man looks at the sea. Then one of them, always the same one, an old gray male with a white collar whom my daughter named Uncle, steps off the edge and drops.

He drops like a stone for the length of my arm. And then the wings open.

The sound of a pigeon's wings opening is like a book slammed shut by a child. *Clap*. And then the others follow, *clap clap clap clap*, out over the courtyard and over the wall, and they turn, all together, as if they were one bird with twenty-two hearts. No one leads. No one gives an order. They simply turn. And in the turning the light catches all their undersides at once, and the whole flock flashes white, like a hand opening.

Then they go up, in circles, wider and higher, until they are no longer birds, only a kind of glitter, a handful of salt thrown at the sky. And you keep watching, because the whole art of it is in the coming down. A good flock comes home. A bad flock goes to another man's roof.

So you stand. And you look up. And you wait for them to come back to you.

This is what I do every morning of my life.

—

My daughter is called Parisa [pa-ree-SAA]. It means *like a fairy*, which she is not. She is like a goat. She is eight years old and climbs everything that can be climbed and some things that cannot. She has a gap in her front teeth where a new one is coming, and she whistles through it, badly, all day, until her mother sends her outside.

She has a pair of sandals I bought her in the bazaar in Kabul, pink plastic with a yellow plastic flower on each toe, and she loves them more than she loves either of her parents. She will not let them be taken off her feet even when she sleeps. She will be buried in her

sandals, Laila said to me once, laughing, and I laughed too, and God forgive us both.

Most mornings she comes up the outside stairs in those sandals, *slap, slap, slap*, and stands next to me with her head back, though she does not know what she is looking for, and says, "Where are they, Baba?" *Baba* [BAA-baa] is what our children call their fathers.

"Up," I say.

"I can't see them."

"That is because they are very good. The good ones go so high that only God and I can see them."

"You can't see them either."

"No," I say. "But I know where they are."

And she puts her small hand in mine, which is cold from the stairs, and we stand on the roof together and look up at the sky.

That is how He saw us, I suppose, if He was looking. A man and a girl on a roof at dawn with their faces turned up, as if they were waiting for something to come down.

—

I fix things. Radios, televisions, and now telephones, because there is not a family in Maidan Shahr without a telephone, and not a telephone in Maidan Shahr that does not break. I have a shop in the bazaar the size of a horse stall, with a table and a lamp and a soldering iron my father bought from a Russian soldier for a sack of rice, in a year I do not want to remember.

The shop opens when the birds come down. That is my rule.

That summer, the summer I am telling you about, we were happy.

I want to say this clearly. Afterwards, people tell the story of a family like mine as if it were always going to end the way it ended. As if we were walking toward it the whole time with our heads down. We were not. We were three people in a house with a sticking door and a mulberry tree. Laila sewed dresses for the women of the street on a black Chinese sewing machine with a gold dragon painted on its side. Parisa went to the girls' school by the river and climbed the mulberry tree in the afternoons. In the

evenings we drank green tea in the courtyard, and when the heat came we carried our mattresses up to the roof and slept under the stars, as everyone does in summer, because the house holds the heat of the day like a hand holds a stone.

We were happy. We did not know it. That is the only way to be happy. If you know it, you are already afraid.

—

And that summer, there was the sound.

I do not know when it began. It came the way the summer heat comes, a little at a time, until one day you notice you have been sweating for a week. A high, thin, faraway buzzing, like a mosquito trapped in another room. You heard it most at night, and at dawn, when the town was quiet. It came from nowhere, and from up.

Everyone knew what it was. No one said it. By that summer, the children in our part of the country could tell you the sounds of the sky the way children elsewhere can tell you the names of footballers. This is a helicopter. This is a jet, too high to matter. This is the other thing, the one you cannot see, that goes around and around and never lands.

Parisa called it the mosquito.

"Baba, the mosquito's back," she would say on the roof at night, lying between Laila and me with her sandals on.

"It's not for us."

"How do you know?"

"Because we are nobody," I said. "It is looking for somebody."

That was what everybody believed. That it was looking for the bad men in the mountains, the ones with guns, the ones in the trucks. That it had no interest in a man with a soldering iron and twenty-two birds. That if you were nobody, you were safe, because nobody was invisible.

So in the mornings, when I stood on the roof and waited for my birds and the sound was there, I did what you do when a stranger stands across the street watching your house. I did not hide. Hiding is what guilty men do.

I looked up at it.

I nodded to it, the way you nod to a neighbor.

Good morning, I said in my heart. I am only a *kaftar-baz*. I am only waiting for my birds.

THREE · Kayla

People think you just push a button.

You don't. I want that on the record before anything else is. There are rules. There are so many rules they come in binders, and there's a guy at the schoolhouse whose whole job is to make you say them back to him like the Pledge of Allegiance. Let me tell you the rules. Not because they'll make you feel better. Because they made *me* feel better, for a while, and I want you to see how.

Rule one is positive identification. They call it PID. It means you have to know who you're looking at. Not think. Know. Before anybody fires anything, somebody has to be able to say: that man is the person on the list. And if there's any doubt about whether somebody is a civilian, the rule says you treat them as one. That's the law. When in doubt, he's a farmer. *No PID, no strike*. The instructor said it so many times it turned into one word, like a spell.

Rule two is the collateral damage estimate. Collateral damage is the military way of saying everybody else. The wife. The kid. The guy selling cigarettes on the wrong corner. Before a strike, somebody sits down with a map and a set of tables and works out who else gets hurt if this missile hits that spot. How big the blast is. Whether the wall is mud or concrete. Whether the room next door has people in it, and how many, and when they go to sleep. You don't do the math. But you feed it. You're the one who says, *two adults and a child sleep in the back room, east side, lights out around ten*. You're the eyes the math is built on. They told us the chance of hurting anybody who isn't the target has to come out under ten percent.

Rule three is the rules of engagement: who is allowed to say yes. In Afghanistan, that year, the yes didn't come from me or the pilot. It came from a commander somewhere else. A lawyer read the package. The commander signed it. We were the hands at the end of a long arm.

Rule four doesn't have a name. Rule four is: *You are not a killer. You are a link.*

Nobody said that one out loud. They didn't need to. It was in the way the whole thing was built. Intelligence finds the phone. Analysts in another state, called screeners, watch the same video I watch and say what they see. The mission intelligence coordinator, the MIC, who sits behind us with a headset and a laptop and a permanent cold, puts it together. The lawyer checks it. The commander signs. The pilot flies. I point.

Nobody kills anybody. Everybody does a little piece.

It's a good feeling. That's what I want you to understand. It's like carrying a coffin with six other people, where nobody's arm does all the work, and nobody's arm is to blame for how heavy it is.

—

The other thing they teach you is pattern of life. It's what I did to that house for forty-one days.

It means you watch somebody until you know their life better than they do. When they wake. When they eat. Who comes to the door, what they carry, where they go and whether they come back the same way. You learn what normal is for that house, and then you look for the thing that isn't.

You'd be amazed what you know after a month.

I knew the woman. I never saw her face, because she covered it when she went out, and in the courtyard the tree was in the way. But she worked at something in a ground-floor room that made her bend over a table for hours, and in the late afternoon she'd come out and stand with both hands on the small of her back and stretch, and I'd stretch too, in my chair, without thinking, like a yawn going around a room.

I knew the girl. From three miles up I could see her shoes. Pink sandals, with a dot of yellow on the toe. She wore them up the tree. She wore them on the roof at night, when they all slept up there in the heat, three white shapes in a row, a big one and a medium one and a little one, like a goddamn bedtime story.

And I knew the man. He walked with his right shoulder a little lower than his left, like he'd spent his life carrying something on that side. He had a shop in the bazaar, a little hole in a long row of little holes. In the evenings men came to his courtyard, one or two at a time, and drank tea, and left. And the phone was still there.

The phone. The selector. It slept at his house most nights. And here's what made the MIC stop sniffing for once: in the mornings, the phone went up to the roof. The man goes up, the phone goes up.

"What's he doing up there," the MIC said.

"Chickens," I said, because that's what Torres had said.

The MIC zoomed his own screen. They weren't chickens. They were too small, and they were up on little shelves in the wire.

"Pigeons," the pilot said, with his mouth full of turkey sandwich. "My granddad kept pigeons. For racing. People used to send messages with them."

And there it was. Nobody said it. It came into the room the way the cold came in, through the vents, and settled on us. *Messages*. A man who sleeps with a bad guy's phone, takes it to the roof every morning, and keeps the birds people used to send messages with.

Not one of us thought he was sending messages by pigeon. It was 2019. But it went into the picture anyway. A little gray smudge in the corner of a painting that you'd swear wasn't there, and that changes the whole thing.

—

I'd get home around seven in the morning. Wyatt would be eating cereal at the counter in his dinosaur pajamas, and I'd stand in the kitchen with my keys still in my hand and do the stupidest thing.

I'd count him.

One. Big as a lamp. Warm.

"Mom, you smell like the airplane," he'd say.

"Airplanes don't smell, dummy."

"Yours does."

He was right. The box got into your hair.

Then I'd lie down in the dark with the blackout curtains closed and a fan going for the noise, and behind my eyelids the house would be there. The blue door. The tree. The man on the roof with his face turned up. Like a song stuck in your head. Like when you've driven all day and lie down and still feel the road moving under you.

That's all it was. I didn't feel bad. Not then. I want to be clear, so you know I'm not lying to make myself look better. I was doing my job, and I was good at it, and I liked being good at it.

I liked the house. I'll say it again, because it's the worst thing in this whole story, and nobody ever believes it.

I liked them.

FOUR • Nasim

A telephone is a little box full of other people.

My father taught me this, though he never saw a mobile telephone in his life. He said it of radios. Be gentle when you open a radio, Nasim, because inside it are a thousand people who have not finished talking.

I do not believe this. But I open them gently. You never know.

—

That summer I had more telephones than I had ever had. They came to me in plastic bags and handkerchiefs and the pockets of men who had walked two days from the villages to the south. Cracked faces. Dead batteries. Charging holes full of sand.

The ones I could not finish in the shop, I took home. Laila did not like it. She said I brought the bazaar into the house. But the shop had one lamp and a generator that coughed like an old man, and the house had better light, and green tea. So in the evenings I sat under the mulberry tree with a tray of broken telephones on my knees, and Parisa sat beside me and handed me the tiny screws, which she kept in the lid of a jam jar and counted out loud.

"Twelve," she said. "Baba, why does it need twelve screws?"

"So that it does not fall apart."

"I don't have twelve screws."

"You have more," I said. "You have a hundred. They are inside, where no one can see them."

She looked at her arm very hard, as if she might see them.

After I fixed a telephone, I had to test it. In Maidan Shahr the signal comes and goes like a cat. In the courtyard it would not come at all. The only place it was always strong was the roof. So every night, and every morning when I went up to the birds, I carried the telephones up in a cloth bag and set them in a row on the low wall at the edge of the roof, like children waiting for the school bus, and watched their little screens light up as they found the tower on the hill.

This is how a telephone tells you it is alive. A small light. A bar, two bars, three.

I did not know that someone was counting the same bars.

—

That summer, a young man came to the shop. I have thought about him every day since, and I still do not know what to think.

He was perhaps twenty-five, with a short beard and very clean hands. He did not give me his name, and I did not ask. In our country, in those years, you did not ask a man's name if he did not offer it. It was a way of keeping each other alive.

His telephone was a cheap black Samsung with a cracked back held together with tape. The charging hole was broken. I fixed it, and he paid me more than I asked. A week later he came back, and the hole was broken again, and he left it with me again. That happened three times, four times, that summer. Each time I took it home. Each time it slept on my wall, in the row, with the others.

I never looked at what was inside it. The names. The calls. That is the first rule of a man who fixes telephones, the same as a doctor's or a priest's. You do not read the letters in the box.

Once he brought Parisa a sweet wrapped in green paper. She ate it in one bite and asked for another, and Laila scolded her for asking, and the young man laughed. He laughed with his whole face, the way young men do before they learn not to.

I know now what *they* thought he was. I have read it in English, on paper, with a seal on top. But I do not know who he was. A man who laughs with his whole face at a little girl asking for a second sweet. A man whose telephone, they say, belonged to men who sent other men to die. Maybe he was both. Maybe most men are.

—

"The birds are enough," Laila said. "Now you have telephones sleeping with the birds."

"Laila," I said. "*Qatra qatra darya mesha* [KAT-ra KAT-ra DAR-ya mee-SHA]."

It is an old saying of ours: *drop by drop, a river is made*. Every telephone I fixed at home was a little more money, and every little more was for Parisa, for a real school in Kabul one day, with a library, for a girl who counted screws and asked why.

Laila looked at me the way she did when I was being clever.

"Drop by drop," she said, "a river is made. And drop by drop, a roof falls in."

That is not a saying. She made it up. She was always making up sayings and pretending they were old, and fooling the women of the street with them. She meant only that the roof was old and I was putting too much on it: birds, telephones, a grown man, a growing girl.

I laughed.

I have thought about that sentence more than any sentence in my life, including the ones in the Holy Book. I know it was a joke about a roof. I know that God does not speak through the jokes of seamstresses.

I know it.

FIVE • Kayla

Day thirty-three.

I remember because I wrote it at the top of the page. I wrote everything down. That was the job. You watch, you write. Time, what you saw, what it might mean. It was called the log, and it went

up the chain: the MIC, the screeners, the intel people, the lawyer, the commander. Everybody read my log. My log was the house. Nobody up the chain had been there.

That's a hell of a thing to be. The only one who knows somebody.

—

By day thirty-three the picture had a shape. That's how the intelligence people talk about it. *Building a picture*, like a puzzle on a card table at your grandma's house. Here are the pieces, the way they went up the chain:

The selector sleeps at the house, most nights.

The selector goes to the roof every morning at first light, with the man.

Military-age males visit in the evenings, alone or in pairs, for under an hour.

The man carries sacks up to the roof two or three times a week. Contents unknown.

The man stands on the roof every morning and looks at the sky.

Now the other way. The way I'd tell it to you on my couch with a beer.

He fixes phones, you idiot. He tests them on the roof because that's where the signal is. The men in the evenings are customers, or neighbors, drinking tea, because in that part of the world they drink tea at you until you die. The sacks are bird feed. The looking up is him watching his birds.

I know that now. But here's what I need you to understand, or nothing else in this book will make sense.

I could have seen it then.

Every piece had a second face, a harmless one, and any of us could have turned it over. Nobody did. Not because we were evil, or stupid. Because of the way a picture builds. Once the first piece goes down, the next one fits beside it. You stop asking what each piece is. You start asking where it goes. There's a name for it, I found out later, in a book a shrink gave me: confirmation bias. Once you believe a thing, your brain goes looking for proof and walks

right past everything that says you're wrong. Everybody does it. You did it at breakfast.

We just did it with a Hellfire.

And the birds.

This is the part I've never told anyone. Not the investigators. Not the shrink. Not my mother.

Some mornings, in the daylight camera, I saw something over the house. A gray flicker, a little cloud of grain that rose and spun and caught the light and went white and then gray and then white again, all at once, like somebody shaking out a sheet. It went up in circles until it was gone.

I saw it more than once. I thought: dust. I thought: a glitch, the satellite hiccuping. I thought: birds, maybe.

I didn't zoom out.

The camera was on the man. That's where you keep it. They teach you the camera is a straw, not a window. You only see what you point it at. I had it pointed at a man on a roof, so what I saw was a man on a roof with his face turned up.

And I wrote, in the log, on day thirty-three, at 0544 local time, in the small block capitals they taught us so nobody could misread anything:

SUBJECT ON ROOF. LOOKS UP AT AIRCRAFT AT DAWN, DAILY.
POSSIBLE AWARENESS OF SURVEILLANCE.

You have to understand what that means, up the chain. Nobody innocent looks up. That's the thinking. Farmers look at the ground. Shopkeepers look at the street. A man who goes up on his roof every morning and looks *right at you* is a man who knows what's up there and is checking it's still there.

That's what I meant. God help me. That's exactly what I meant.

The MIC read it and said, "Huh," and typed something into his laptop.

The pilot said, "Creepy," and went back to his sandwich.

I sat there with the camera on the man, and the man stood with his face turned up at me, and for one second, with the lag, it felt like he was a second and a half ahead of me. Like he'd already seen me, and I was only now seeing him seeing me.

I waved. I don't know why. A little wave with two fingers, below the desk where nobody could see, like you'd wave at a baby through a car window.

He didn't wave back. He couldn't see me. He was looking at his birds.

—

Things moved after that, slowly and then fast. The package went up. *Nominated* was the word, like an Oscar. The lawyer read it. The commander, whoever he was, read my log.

And the math came back with a plan, and here's the part that will make you sick.

The plan was the dawn.

The best time to strike, the math said, is when the man is alone on the roof. Most nights that summer the three of them slept up there together, so the plan carried a condition: the first dawn the wife and the girl were below, in the back room on the east side, where the log said they went when they came down. A small missile, the kind made for exactly this, aimed at the man on the roof at first light. The blast stays on the roof. The people under it are outside the circle. The chance of hurting them comes out under the line.

It was the most careful plan I ever saw. It was built out of my log. It knew the man was on that roof every morning at first light, because I'd told it. It knew where the woman and the child slept, because I'd told it. It was designed, every inch of it, to kill him and nobody else.

To protect them. That's what it was for.

You understand? The thing that marked him was his habit of standing on that roof, and the thing that was supposed to save his family was his habit of standing on that roof.

Every morning. Without fail.

Never once, in thirty-three days, had he missed.

SIX · Nasim

On the fortieth night we slept on the roof that summer, the wind came.

We had been sleeping on the roof for weeks. You carry up the thin cotton mattresses in the evening and lay them in a row, and lie with your face to the sky, and the stars are so many and so close you feel you could put one in your pocket. You hear the whole town settling. A donkey. A radio. A mother calling a child in for the last time. Then only the dogs, and the crickets, and that summer, the sound.

Parisa lay between us. She always did. She said it was the safest place in Afghanistan, and I told her she was right.

"Baba," she said. "The mosquito."

"I hear it."

"Is it looking at us?"

"It is like the moon," I said. "It looks at everyone, and so it looks at no one."

She was quiet a while. You could always hear her thinking. Her breath changed.

"Tell me the bird story."

—

There is a story in our old book, the *Shahnameh* [SHAAH-naa-meh], the Book of Kings, a thousand years old, which every child in our part of the world knows in pieces. In it there is a bird called the Simorgh [see-MORGH].

She is as big as a cloud, and very old, and very wise, and she lives at the top of a mountain so high no man has ever climbed it. From there she sees everything. Every valley. Every house. Every child.

Once, a king had a baby son born with white hair, white as an old man's, and the king was ashamed, and left the baby at the foot of the mountain to die. And the Simorgh saw. She came down and lifted the baby gently in her claws and raised him in her nest with her own children. His name was Zal [ZAAL]. When he was grown

and wanted to go down the mountain and live among men, she gave him three of her feathers. If ever you are in danger, she said, burn one, and wherever I am, I will see the smoke, and I will come.

I told it to her every night that summer, and every night she asked the same questions, and I gave the same answers.

"Did he burn the feathers?"

"He did, when his wife was dying. And the Simorgh came, and saved them both."

"So the Simorgh watches us?"

"The Simorgh watches everyone. That is her job."

That night, the fortieth night, she asked a new question.

"Baba. Is the mosquito a Simorgh?"

I lay there with the sound going around and around above us, high and thin and patient, and I thought about it.

"No," I said.

"How do you know?"

"Because the Simorgh comes down. That is the whole point of her. She watches, and when you need her, she comes down. The mosquito only watches."

"Maybe it will come down."

"Maybe," I said. "Go to sleep, *jan* [JAAN]."

Jan means life. It is what we call the ones we love. *Parisa-jan*. My life.

—

After midnight the wind came over the mountains from the west, bringing the dust, the way it does at the end of summer. Not a storm. Only a gritty wind that gets into your teeth and your eyes.

Laila sat up and coughed. "I'm taking her down."

"Leave her. It will pass."

"It's in her mouth, Nasim. I'm taking her down."

So she lifted Parisa, who did not wake, who was too heavy now to be lifted and was lifted anyway, the way mothers do, with a small grunt. Parisa's sandals dangled from her feet, pink, with the yellow flowers. Laila carried her down the outside stairs, slowly, in the dark, and I heard the door of the house stick and then give, and then I heard nothing.

They slept in the back room, on the east side, where it is coolest. They always did, when they came down.

I stayed on the roof.

I could have gone down. I think of that. I could have rolled up my mattress and slept on the floor of the back room with my wife and daughter, and been there, under the roof, with them.

But the birds were restless in the wind, *hoo-oo, hoo-oo*, worried, and I did not want to leave them. So I lay down again, alone, with my scarf over my face against the grit, and I listened to the wind and the birds and the sound, and I slept.

—

I woke at first light. My body knows the hour better than any clock.

The wind had gone. The air was washed and cold and very clear, as if someone had wiped the whole sky with a wet cloth. The mountains were black. The town was blue. The sky over the eastern ridge was the color that has no name.

I folded my mattress and set it by the stairs. I opened the loft.

Uncle came to the edge and looked at me with one orange eye, as he did every morning, as if to ask, *Is it time?*

"It's time," I said.

He stepped off and dropped, and the wings opened. *Clap*. And the others went after him, out over the mulberry tree, and they turned, and in the first light from the east the flock flashed white all at once, like a hand opening.

I stood with my head back and watched them rise, wider and higher, until they were a handful of salt.

The sound was there. High and thin and patient.

I looked up at it. I nodded.

Good morning, I said in my heart. I am only a *kaftar-baz*.

I am only waiting for my birds.

INTERLUDE ONE • 1861-1863

A Short History of Watching from Above

The Man in the Basket

This is a true story, from the first American war in which an army watched its enemy from the sky. It is about the oldest part of a drone strike, the part that comes before everything else: the looking.

In the summer of 1861, the United States was at war with itself, and Washington was a nervous city, close enough to the enemy that on a clear day you could almost feel them across the river.

A balloonist named Thaddeus Lowe had an idea. What if a man went up in a balloon, tied to the ground by a rope, and simply *looked*? Generals had always had to guess what was on the other side of the hill. From high enough, a man could see over every hill at once, and count the enemy's tents and cannons, and watch which way they marched.

In June 1861, Lowe rose over Washington with a telegraph wire running down the rope, and from the sky he sent a message to President Lincoln. It said, more or less: *I can see for fifty miles in every direction*. It was the first time anyone had sent words straight down from the sky. Soon Lowe's balloons were following the Union Army from battle to battle, with men hanging in wicker baskets in the cold, watching, and sending down what they saw.

Here is the part that matters to this book.

The men in the baskets could be seen.

A balloon is a very large thing. The soldiers below could see it hanging over their camp like a second moon. On a clear day they could see the man in the basket. And they did what soldiers do: they fired at him. The watcher and the watched could see each other, and each could kill the other.

That was the bargain, in the beginning. If you want to watch a man from above, you have to let him look back at you.

Two years later, in the same war, under the same president, something else happened that almost nobody connects to the balloons.

In April 1863, Lincoln signed a set of written rules for how his soldiers must behave. It was called the Lieber Code [LEE-ber], after the professor who wrote it, and it was one of the first times any army wrote its rules down. Among many things, it said that unarmed citizens should be spared, as much as the needs of war allowed.

As much as the needs of war allowed. Somebody always has to decide what the needs of war allow, and who is unarmed.

Who decides? And how would a man in a basket, a mile up, tell a farmer from a soldier who had put down his rifle to eat?

In the same war, signed by the same hand, came the first eye in the sky and the first written promise to protect people who are not fighting. One was a way of seeing everything. The other was a promise about what you would do with what you saw. It would take them a hundred and fifty years to meet.

The Balloon Corps did not last. By the summer of 1863, the balloons were packed away.

But before they were, a Southern boy in a gray coat looked up from his campfire in a field in Virginia and saw one hanging above the trees. He could see the basket, and the small dark shape of the man in it, leaning over the edge with a spyglass, or a pencil, or only his own two hands holding on. For a moment the two of them looked at each other across the empty air. A man looking down. A man looking up. Each could see the other. Each could, if he wanted, try to kill the other.

They were equals, for that one moment.

The boy raised his hand to shade his eyes. Maybe he meant it as a salute. Maybe he meant nothing at all.

It was the last time the watched would see the watcher's face.

II. BUGSPLAT

SEVEN • Kayla

The chicken.

I want to start with the chicken, because that's where the day started, and because for a long time afterwards it was the only part of the day I could stand to think about.

I woke at ten past one in the afternoon with the blackout curtains closed and the fan going and my mouth tasting like a penny. The light around the edges of the curtains was that hard white Las Vegas light that looks less like daylight than a fluorescent tube somebody left on in God's garage.

And I thought: *the chicken*.

I'd bought a pack of thighs on Sunday, family size, on sale, and every day that week I'd meant to take them out of the freezer in the morning, and every day I'd come home from killing nobody and gone straight to bed and forgotten. So that was the first thing I did on the day. I went into the kitchen in a T-shirt and underwear and put the frozen thighs in the sink in a bowl of cold water, the way my mother taught me, because she said only white trash thawed meat in the microwave.

I stood there and watched the water go cloudy around the plastic.

That's the last clean memory. The chicken in the bowl in the sink. The water turning white.

—

Wyatt was at school until three. I did the laundry. A seven-year-old boy makes laundry like he's training for something. Grass stains, ketchup, a sock that had been in a puddle and then in the hamper for a week and had become something new, with its own opinions. His dino-jammies, though he'd started telling me he was too old for that word. The socks that didn't match went into the Basket of Lonely Socks, which is a real basket in my house, and which Wyatt named, and which he checks every week like a lost and found.

I folded his clothes and I didn't think about Afghanistan.

That's not a brag. People think you carry it around all day. You can't. Your hands do small things and your mind does small things,

and the war sits in a box in the desert forty-five minutes away, waiting for you, the way the office waits for anybody.

On the counter was a permission slip. Second grade was going to the Hoover Dam. I signed it, checked *no* for allergies, put a ten and a one in the envelope for the bus, and licked it, and it tasted like glue and summer. I'd lived in Vegas six years and never been to the Hoover Dam. I thought: I should go with them. I should ask for a day.

I put the envelope in the front pocket of his backpack, where he'd find it.

—

My mother called at two-fifteen. She calls every Wednesday. She lives in Henderson with a man named Gary who sells pool chemicals, and she believes, with her whole heart, that I am in the business of murder and that Jesus will forgive me if I ask Him nicely.

"Are you eating," she said.

"I'm thawing chicken."

"In the sink?"

"In the sink, Mom."

"Good girl." And then, the way you'd say *drive safe*: "Are you going to kill anybody today?"

"I don't kill anybody, Mom. I point a camera."

"Well," she said, "point it nice."

She laughed. I laughed. It had been our joke for two years. It was the worst joke in the world and we both knew it, and that was why it worked. You can say anything if you say it like it's funny.

I didn't know. I want to tell you I felt something, a shadow, a chill. I didn't. The package had gone up the chain two days before and was sitting on some desk, waiting for some signature, and nobody tells the sensor operator when the signature comes. They tell you when you sit down.

I picked Wyatt up at three. He got in the back with his face red from the playground and told me without stopping for breath that a kid named Jaden had eaten a whole blue crayon and his poop was going to be blue.

"Gross," I said.

"I know," he said, delighted.

I made him a grilled cheese, cut in triangles. I put the chicken in a dish with lemon and garlic and salt and left a note for the sitter: *350 for 40 min. Make him eat a vegetable. A pickle counts.* We did his spelling words. That week they all ended in *-ight. Light. Night. Bright. Right. Fight. Sight.* He spelled *sight* like *site*. I told him that was a different word, a place where something happens, like a building site. He said two words that sound the same and mean different things was stupid. I said that was English.

The sitter came at four-thirty. I kissed Wyatt on the top of the head, which smelled like crayons and grilled cheese and boy.

"Bye, Mom. Fly the airplane."

"I'll fly it."

"Fly it high."

"Always," I said.

On the drive up, the sun was behind me and the desert was the color of a lion. Highway 95 runs northwest out of Las Vegas straight as a ruler, mountains on the left getting closer and redder, dry lake beds on the right as flat and white as spilled flour. There are things I remember about that drive that I have no business remembering. A hawk on a telephone pole. A white Corolla on a donut spare. Ninety-four degrees on the dashboard. The steering wheel too hot to hold at the top, so I drove with my hands at the bottom, like a teenager.

—

The pilot was already in his chair with his turkey sandwich unwrapped on his knee.

"Morning, sunshine," he said.

And then, before I could tell him to fuck off: "It came through."

That's all. *It came through.* The way you'd say a check had cleared.

Torres gave me his chair and the brief. Fuel, weapons, weather. Clear sky, light wind from the west, dropping. The dust that had come through in the night had blown out. It was going to be a beautiful morning in Maidan Shahr.

"Package approved," he said. "Execute at first light. Target on the roof, alone, PID holds." He clapped me on the shoulder. "Your boy, Rourke. You found him."

Your boy.

I sat down.

On the screen it was a quarter past five in the morning. The house was where it always was, the courtyard dark, the tree a black puff. In white hot, the roof glowed faintly, the bricks still holding a little of yesterday's heat. And on the roof, near the cage, one white shape. Lying down. Alone.

"Where are the other two," the MIC said, behind me.

I rolled back through the night crew's notes and read it out. *0047L. Adult female and child move from roof to ground floor, east room. Wind.*

"East room," the MIC said. "Good. That's outside the circle."

"That's outside the circle," the pilot said, and took a bite of his sandwich.

And I sat with my hands on the controls and looked at the one white shape curled on its side, and I thought about the chicken in the oven forty-five minutes south, and the spelling words, and the eleven dollars in the front pocket of a backpack.

Light. Night. Bright. Right. Fight. Sight.

I thought: *it's just a morning.*

I thought: *he's going to get up and go to the cage, the way he always does.*

He always did.

EIGHT • Nasim

When the birds are up, there is a time that belongs to no one.

They are too high to watch and too soon to come down, a glitter somewhere over the eastern ridge, and you know they will not come home for half an hour. You cannot leave the roof, because you must be there when they return. My father called it the empty cup: the time after you have poured the tea and before it is cool enough to drink.

Most men fill the empty cup with nothing. I do the work of the loft. I will tell you what that work is, because it was the last work I did with that life, and I want somebody besides me to know it.

—

First, the water.

There is a shallow clay dish in the loft that collects dust and feathers in the night. I tipped it over the edge of the roof, the way I always did, and the water fell in one long rope and made a dark star in the dust of the street. Then I carried the dish down the outside stairs to the tap in the courtyard. The mulberry tree was full of sparrows, waking up and arguing. The tap coughed twice before it gave water, as if it had to remember, every morning, what water is. I filled the dish and carried it back up step by step, in both hands, like a man carrying a lamp.

Behind the door below me I could hear Laila. The scrape of the iron plate on the gas ring, the soft *whump* of the flame, the clink of the teapot lid. She coughed once, from the dust of the night.

"Up," she said to Parisa. "Up, up. The school will not come to you."

And Parisa, from under the blanket, in a voice like a cat being sat on: "Five minutes."

Every child in the world says five minutes, in every language. I believe it is the first sentence God gave to children, before *mother* or *father* or *bread*.

Second, the floor.

I scraped the boards of the loft with a flat tin blade. It is a good sound, the scraper on the wood, a long dry sound like a man clearing his throat before he says something important. The loft smelled of birds, warm and dusty and a little sweet, like the inside of an old coat.

The town was waking. The baker on the corner had lit his *tandoor* [tan-DOOR], the round clay oven sunk into the ground, and the smell of the bread came over the wall, hot stone and flour, the smell of every morning of my life. A radio was playing the news from Kabul in a voice trying very hard to sound calm. A boy drove goats down the street, tapping their bony backs with a stick and singing to them, a song with no words.

The sky was growing pale. Not blue yet. The white before blue.

Third, the grain.

I filled the trays: wheat, a little broken corn, and a handful of the yellow lentils Laila used for soup, because my father always said a pigeon who eats lentils flies home faster, and I have never been able to prove he was wrong. The grain made a soft hiss as it poured. It is one of the sounds I hear at night, now.

Then I took the telephones out of the cloth bag and set them in their row on the low wall. Eleven of them that day. I have counted them in my head ten thousand times since. A Nokia with no back. A Huawei with a face like a spider's web. And the young man's cheap black Samsung, with the tape around its middle like a bandage, fixed again the evening before and ready for him to collect.

I pressed the buttons one by one, and they woke, their little screens blue and green in the gray light. One bar. Two bars. Three.

There, I thought. You are alive.

I sat on the edge of the roof with my legs over the side and waited for the birds.

Below me, the mulberry tree, the tap, the blue door that sticks. To the east, the window of the back room, open for the cool of the morning, the white curtain Laila had sewn moving a little in and out, as if the room were breathing.

Through the curtain I could hear Parisa looking for her other sandal. She slept in them, and still, every morning, one of them escaped in the night and hid.

"Mama, where's my sandal?"

"Where you left it."

"I didn't leave it, it left me."

I laughed out loud on the roof, alone, and a sparrow flew out of the mulberry tree in fright.

And I thought, in exactly these words, with the cold coming up off the bricks and the bread in my nose: *I must fix that door. Today. I will fix it today.*

The sky was blue now. The sun was not over the ridge yet, but the light was coming, the way the sound of a river comes before you see the river. The high thin buzzing was there, as it was every morning. Going around and around.

And far away, over the eastern ridge, I saw the flock.

You see them first as a flicker, a handful of dust that catches the light and goes dark again. Then they turn and flash white, all together, and you know them, the way you would know your own child's voice in a crowd. My birds. Coming home.

I stood. I brushed the grit off my trousers. I went to the middle of the roof, by the loft, where I always stand to call them in, and put my fingers to my mouth to whistle the whistle they know.

I looked up.

NINE • Kayla

Here is how it goes, the last minutes. Not the way it goes in movies. In movies there's music.

There's no music. There's the hum of the air conditioner. There's the MIC sniffing behind you. There's the pilot chewing. There's a voice in your headset from somewhere else, flat and calm, like a man reading a weather report. There's the screen. And there's your hand.

—

At 0538 local, the white shape on the roof sat up.

"Target's awake," I said. You say everything out loud, so it goes on the tape. "Sitting up."

He stood and stretched, both arms over his head, and his heat bloomed a little as he moved, the way a coal brightens when you blow on it. He folded his mattress and set it by the stairs. Then he went to the cage and opened it, and a scatter of small dim specks came out, barely warmer than the air, and went up off the edge of the roof all at once. In the daylight camera on my second screen, they flashed silver. All together.

"There go Granddad's racers," the pilot said, with his mouth full. "Every damn morning."

The specks spiraled up off the edge of the screen. I didn't follow them. The camera is a straw. You keep it on the target.

"Confirm target is alone on the roof," said the voice.

"Target is alone on the roof."

"Confirm location of additional persons."

"Two additional persons, ground floor, east room. Adult female, child. Outside the effects radius."

"Copy."

—

Then he did what I had watched him do forty times.

I can't explain to you what that does to you, to know a man's morning so well. He went down the stairs with a dish in his hands, slow, careful, like a waiter. At the tap the water came out in white hot as a black thread, colder than anything, and his hands went dim where it touched them. He carried the dish back up. Step by step. He scraped the floor of the cage. He poured something into trays.

And then he took the phones out.

"There it is," the MIC said, quietly, like a man at a fishing hole. "There's the selector."

Eleven little lights in a row on the edge of the roof, blue and green, like the lights on a stereo. And somewhere up the chain, on another screen, a different machine was telling somebody that the selector had just woken up on this roof, with this man, at this moment.

"Selector's active," the voice said. "Location confirms."

Then he sat down on the edge of the roof with his legs hanging over, and he just sat there. Waiting.

For twelve minutes and forty seconds, he sat. He scratched his neck once. He laughed once, I swear to God, a little jump of the shoulders, at something below him in the courtyard I couldn't see. A small bird flew out of the tree.

I sat and watched him sit. The pilot ate his sandwich. In white hot he was one bright candle on the edge of a dark roof, and below him, in the east room, two smaller lights moved around each other. A medium one and a little one. The little one went from one side of the room to the other. Bent down. Stood up. Bent down again.

Looking for something.

—

At 0601 local, the voice said, "You are cleared hot."

Cleared hot. It means everybody up the chain has said yes. The commander, the lawyer, the math, all at once, in two words, from a room I would never see.

The pilot put his sandwich down on a paper towel on the console. Carefully. I remember the paper towel.

"Cleared hot, copy. Arming."

We read the checklist to each other like two people saying grace. Master arm, on. Weapon selected, station two. Laser, ready.

"Sensor, put the spot on him."

I put the spot on him.

The spot is the laser, a beam you can't see with your eyes, coming out of the bottom of the plane three miles up. The missile, once it's off the rail, sees the spot and flies to it, the way a moth flies to a porch light. On my screen it's a little cross with a box around it, and you hold it there. That's the whole job of the sensor operator in the last minute. You hold the box on a man.

I held the box on the white shape in the middle of the roof.

He was standing by the cage. He had his face turned up.

He was looking at me.

—

"Rifle," the pilot said.

It's what you say when the missile leaves the plane. It means it's gone. It means you can't take it back.

There's a little puff at the edge of the frame, from under the wing, and then nothing, because the missile is too fast and too small to see. In the corner of the screen a number appears. The time of flight. How many seconds until it gets there.

It said twenty-two.

Twenty-one.

You'd think that's no time. It's a lot of time. You could say a lot of things in twenty-two seconds. You could say *I'm sorry*. You could say *wait*. You could tell a man everything about his life.

Twenty.

I held the box on him.

Nineteen.

He put two fingers to his mouth. I saw his hand go up to his face and thought, for one second, *he's waving*.

He wasn't waving. He was whistling.

Eighteen.

Seventeen.

And then a thing happened that I have watched in my head more times than any other single thing in my life. More than my son being born. It's three seconds long and I could draw it for you with my eyes shut.

Something came down out of the sky and landed on him.

A small cold speck. One bird, the first one back, dropping out of the gray onto his raised hand.

And he turned.

He turned away from the middle of the roof, toward the east side, toward the top of the stairs and the window of the back room below, as if someone had called him. One step. Two. Three. Holding the bird against his chest.

Sixteen.

"He's moving," I said.

"Stay on him," the pilot said.

And I did what I was trained to do, what my hands knew how to do better than my mind did. I stayed on him. I slewed the box after him, east, toward the stairs, toward the room where the two smaller lights were.

A second and a half.

That's the lag. I moved the box, and for a second and a half it didn't move, and then it moved, and by then he'd moved more, so I moved it more. You lead. You learn to lead, like you'd lead a duck with a shotgun. I pushed the box east, and east, after the bright shape walking toward the stairs with a bird in its arms.

Fifteen.

Fourteen.

And the box slid off him.

He was faster than the lag. He took one long step onto the top of the stairs and turned to go down, and the box I had been holding on

him for forty-one days slid off the edge of his shoulder and onto the roof beside him.

Onto the roof over the east room.

Thirteen.

"I'm off him," I said. "I'm off him—"

"Get back on."

Twelve.

I moved my hand.

A second and a half.

Eleven.

The box didn't move.

Ten.

Nine.

The box moved. Not far enough. He was on the stairs now, going down, and the box was on the flat mud roof, on the bricks still holding a little of yesterday's heat, a foot from the edge, over the room where the log said the woman and the child would be.

Eight.

Seven.

In the east room, the little white shape bent down. Stood up. Held something up in its hand.

It had found it. Whatever it was looking for, it had found it.

Six.

Five.

I did not move my hand again.

The investigators asked me why, twice. The first time I said there wasn't time, the missile was in its last seconds and couldn't turn hard enough to follow, which is true. The second time I said I froze, which is also true.

There's a third answer I never gave them.

I didn't move my hand again because I was afraid that if I moved it, I'd move it the wrong way. And I knew, the way you know something with your whole body, that every direction was the wrong way. That I was holding a little box of light on the roof of a house where a man was carrying a bird down the stairs toward his daughter, and that wherever I put it, it was going to land on somebody's morning.

Four.

Three.

Two.

On the screen, the two small white shapes in the east room were very close together. Touching.

One.

TEN • Nasim

I will tell you what I was doing. That is all I can tell you. I was not there for what happened. I was only there for what I was doing.

I was whistling for my birds.

—

Every *kaftar-baz* has his own whistle, the way every man has his own walk. Mine is two notes, one high and one low, and then a third that goes up at the end like a question. My birds know it the way a dog knows its name. When they are high and deciding whether to come home or go to another man's roof, it is the thread that pulls them down.

I put two fingers in my mouth and whistled it. High, low, and the question.

And Uncle came first.

He always came first. He dropped out of the sky like a stone, wings folded, falling and falling until you were sure he had forgotten how to stop, and then, an arm's length above the roof, the wings opened, *clap*, and he put his red feet forward and landed on my hand.

On my hand. He did that sometimes. Only on the good days.

He was cold from the sky. I could feel his heart going very fast against my fingers, so fast it was not a beat but a hum. He looked at me with one orange eye.

Is it time?

"You're early," I said. "Where are the others? Did you leave them?"

—

And below me, from the window of the back room, Parisa shouted.

"Baba! I found it!"

That was all. The sandal. The one that had escaped in the night. She had found it under the mattress or behind the sewing machine, and she wanted me to know, because there was nothing that happened to Parisa that she did not want me to know.

"Show me!" I called.

And I turned, with Uncle against my chest, and walked toward the top of the stairs, to look down at the window and see her hold it up.

I want you to understand how small this was. It was the smallest thing I did that day, smaller than the water, smaller than the grain. I turned around on my own roof to see my daughter hold up a pink plastic shoe. I did not decide to do it. My feet did it, the way your feet go to the door when someone you love knocks.

One step. Two steps. Three.

I put my foot on the first stair and looked down, past the edge of the roof, toward the window with its white curtain going in and out.

I saw, through the gap in the curtain, a small hand, holding up something pink, with a yellow flower on it.

I took the second step.

I was thinking about the door. I was thinking: I will fix it today. After the shop, before the tea. I will plane the bottom where it sticks, the way my father showed me, and when Parisa comes home from school I will open it for her and it will swing like a bird's wing, and she will say, *Baba, it doesn't stick*, and I will say, *No, jan. Nothing sticks anymore.*

I was thinking about that.

I took the third step.

—

There was no sound.

People ask me about the sound. The neighbors said it was the loudest thing they had ever heard, that it broke windows in the next street. I believe them. But there is no sound in my memory. There is only the rest of it.

There was a light.

Not a flash. More like the light that comes into a room when someone opens a door in the dark, only the door was everywhere, and the light was not coming in. It was coming out. Out of the roof. Out of the bricks under my feet. As if the house my father built had been holding a sun inside it all these years, and had finally let it go.

Then I was lifted.

I do not know another word. I was lifted the way you lift a child, under the arms, very fast, by a hand much bigger than mine. The stairs went away from my feet. Uncle went out of my hands. I felt the small hum of his heart leave my fingers, and I did not see where he went.

I was in the air.

I want to tell you that it was terrible. It was not terrible. That is the thing I have never been able to say to anyone. It was quiet. I was turning, slowly, the way my birds turn, and I saw the sky, very blue now, and the edge of the eastern ridge with the sun just coming over it, the first gold of the day. And I saw, very high, above everything, a glitter. A handful of salt.

My birds. Turning all together. Flashing white.

They were coming home.

—

Then I was in the mulberry tree.

My mother's tree, that she planted the year I was born. It caught me. I fell into it from above, and the branches broke under me, crack and crack and crack, leaves in my mouth, the branches

holding me and letting me go and holding me and letting me go, the way a mother hands a baby down a staircase, from arm to arm, and then I was on the ground.

On my back. In the courtyard. Under the tree.

And then, at last, I heard something.

I heard the bricks.

I heard them coming down behind me, where the house was. Not all at once. A long slow sound like a man pouring gravel from a sack, and then a stop, and then a little more. Patient. As if the house were deciding, one brick at a time, what to keep and what to let go.

I heard dust. I did not know dust had a sound. It is the sound of a very large thing breathing out.

The dust came down on me like flour. I could not see the house. I could see only white, falling, slowly, slowly, and in the white, very far away, a gold light where the sun was.

I lay in the white, under my mother's tree, and I thought: *Parisa found her sandal.*

That is what I thought.

I did not think *my house*. I did not think *my wife*. I did not think *my daughter*. Not yet. The mind does not go there first. The mind is kind, for a little while. It gives you one last small thing to hold before it gives you the big one.

She found it, I thought. *Good. Now she can go to school.*

ELEVEN • Kayla

"Splash," the pilot said.

It's what you say when the missile hits. Like a stone in a pond. Like a kid jumping in a pool.

On the white hot screen, the house disappeared.

It didn't explode the way you'd think, fire and a fireball, like the movies. In white hot, the place where the missile lands turns into a flower. A white flower, opening. Petals of heat going out in every direction, very fast, and then slowing, and hanging there, and then

the dust comes up through it, cold and gray, and covers it, like somebody pulling a sheet over a bed.

The flower opened at 0602 and nineteen seconds, local time.

It opened over the east room.

“Good effects,” the pilot said, the way he said it every time. It means the missile did what missiles do. It’s not a judgment. It’s like saying the oven’s hot.

Then he picked his sandwich up off the paper towel, looked at it, and put it down again without eating it. In two years of sitting next to that man, it was the only time I ever saw him not finish his sandwich.

“BDA,” said the voice in my headset. “Stay on it.”

Battle damage assessment. It means you look at what you did. You don’t get to look away. You keep the camera on it so that somebody up the chain can put a number in a box.

So I stayed on it.

The dust took four minutes and eleven seconds to clear. I’ve timed it since, on the tape. In my memory it’s an hour. In my memory I’m still waiting for it to clear.

The roof was gone on the east side. The east room didn’t have a ceiling anymore. It had the ceiling inside it: mud and timber and brick in a gray mound, and on top, in the daylight camera, pieces of the cage. Wire. Wood. Small light scattered things that I told myself were feathers. On the west side the roof still stood, and the place where he had stood every morning was still there, flat and empty.

In white hot, the mound glowed the way a fire glows after you’ve put it out. Dull and low and even, all the heat of the blast settling into the bricks.

I looked for them.

Forty-one days I had been able to find those two shapes anywhere in that house, through any open window. The camera sees heat through a curtain. It sees a sleeping child through a cotton blanket.

It does not see through a house that has fallen.

The mound glowed the same dull warmth from top to bottom. There was no white. No shape. Just the house, lying on top of the room, keeping its secret.

White means warm, I thought. Warm means alive.

There was nothing on my screen to say it to.

—

“Squirter,” the MIC said. It’s the word for somebody who gets out of a strike. “In the courtyard. Under the tree.”

I swung the camera.

A white shape on its back under the tree. Moving, the way a turtle moves on its back. An arm. A leg. It rolled over, slowly, and got up on its hands and knees.

“Is that the target?” said the voice.

“Can’t confirm.”

“Selector status?”

A pause, somewhere. Then: “Selector’s dark.”

The eleven little lights were gone. Under the mound.

“Stay on the squirter.”

So I stayed on him.

He crawled. He crawled across the courtyard on his hands and knees, from the tree to the mound, the way you’d crawl across a dark floor looking for something you’d dropped. And when he got there, he dug.

You can see a lot in white hot. You can see the hands get brighter as a man digs, from the work, from the blood. You can see him throw a brick behind him, and another. You can see that his left arm isn’t working right, that it hangs. You can see him dig with one hand.

Then other shapes came through the gap where the blue door had been. Two, then five, then a dozen. Men, women at the edges, kids. The neighbors, a crowd of candles, running to the mound and kneeling down to dig.

"Multiple military-age males approaching," the MIC said. "Watch them."

"They're digging," I said.

"Watch them."

So I watched them dig.

—

It took them nineteen minutes, with their hands.

Here's something they teach you in the schoolhouse. A body doesn't go cold fast. It holds its heat for hours. On bare ground, in the cool of the morning, a body is the warmest thing for a mile. But under a roof that's just been hit by a missile, everything is warm. The bricks, the timbers, the dust. And the camera spreads its colors across whatever's in front of it, so that when everything is the same temperature, everything is the same gray.

So when the men pulled the last bricks off and lifted them out, the two of them came out the same color as the mound. Not white. Gray. A medium shape wrapped around a little one, so close you couldn't see where one stopped.

They were still warm. I knew it then. The people holding them would have felt it in their hands, and thought what anyone would think: *she's still warm, maybe.*

But on my screen they were the same color as the world.

You couldn't tell them apart from the dirt.

The white shape that had dug with one hand took the little gray one in its arms and sat down on the ground with it, and rocked it, back and forth, very slowly, the way you'd rock a baby to sleep.

And the little gray one didn't get any warmer.

—

I wrote it down. That's the job. In the small block capitals, so nobody could misread anything:

0621L. 2X PERSONS RECOVERED FROM STRUCTURE, EAST ROOM. NO MOVEMENT. ASSESSED AS 2X CIVCAS. ADULT FEMALE, CHILD.

CIVCAS means civilian casualties. It's a word. It goes in a box.

And under it, because the voice asked:

SQUIRTER, ADULT MALE, ALIVE. TARGET STATUS UNCONFIRMED.

—

When the new crew took the chair, the new sensor operator looked at the screen and then at me.

"You good?"

"I'm good."

She didn't believe me. She didn't say anything else. Nobody says anything else. That's the deal.

I got my phone out of the locker. Two texts. One from the sitter: *chicken was amazing!! he ate a pickle lol*. One from my mother: a sunrise over Henderson with a Bible verse across it in curly letters.

On the way home I stopped at the Walmart on Craig Road, because we were out of milk.

It was six-forty in the morning and the store was almost empty, and they were playing a song about being young forever. I got the milk. I got Cheerios. And then I walked past the hot case, where the rotisserie chickens sit in their plastic domes under the heat lamps, in rows.

I stopped.

I stood in front of the rotisserie chickens for I don't know how long. A guy in an apron asked if I needed help, and I said no, and he went away. I just stood there and looked at them, golden, steaming the insides of their little plastic houses. And I thought about how long one would stay warm, if somebody took it out and put it on the

counter. And how you could watch it go, if you had the right camera. From white to gray, a little at a time, so slow you'd never see it unless you watched.

I put the basket down on the floor of the Walmart with the milk and the Cheerios in it, and I walked out.

—

When I got home, Wyatt was at the counter in his dinosaur pajamas, the ones I'd folded the day before, eating toast.

"Mom, you didn't get milk."

"I forgot."

"You always forget."

"I know, baby."

I stood in the kitchen with my keys in my hand and I counted him.

One. Big as a lamp. White.

I put my hand on the back of his neck, under his hair, where it's warmest, and kept it there. "Mom, your hand's cold." I kept it there until he wriggled away and said, "Mom, *stop*," and went to get dressed for school.

He was warm. He was so warm.

I opened the fridge. The sitter had saved me two of the chicken thighs, under foil. I took one out with my fingers, cold, and stood in the light of the open fridge in my uniform and ate it. I hadn't eaten in sixteen hours.

And it was good.

That's the thing I can't tell anyone. The lemon and the garlic and the salt. It was the best thing I'd eaten all week.

I didn't cry. I didn't throw up. I didn't feel anything at all, except that the chicken was good, and I was hungry, and my son was warm.

That's the first day. Nobody tells you that, either. The first day, you don't feel anything.

You just eat the chicken.

TWELVE · Nasim

They let me hold her until the noon prayer.

In our faith, the dead are buried quickly, the same day if it can be done. It is a mercy. It carries the dead into the earth before the house learns to hold the shape of their absence.

At noon the women came and took her from me, gently, the way you take a sleeping child from a man who has fallen asleep holding her.

I did not let go at first.

My cousin Wahid [wa-HEED], who had come running from the other end of town with his shirt on inside out, held my wrists. Not hard. The way you hold the wrists of a drowning man, to help him, not to stop him. *Nasim-jan*, he said in my ear, *she must be washed. Let her be washed.*

And I let her go.

I want to tell you how she looked. I have never told anyone, and I want one person to know.

She looked like she was sleeping. That is what people say, and it was true. There was white dust in her hair, in her eyelashes, in the little gap in her front teeth. There was blood at the back of her head, where I did not look. But her face was clean except for the dust, and her mouth was a little open, the way it always was when she slept, as if she were about to say *five minutes*.

And in her hand was the sandal.

The one she had found. She held it so tightly that the women could not take it out of her fingers, and in the end they did not try. They washed her around it. They wrapped her around it.

Laila was right. She was buried in her sandals. One on her foot and one in her hand.

Laila was holding her when they found them. Wrapped around her, Wahid told me, the way a hand wraps around a stone. Her back was to the falling roof, and Parisa was in the circle of her arms.

She had turned. In the last second she had heard something, or felt a change in the air, the way mothers feel things, and she had turned and put her body between our daughter and the roof.

It did not help.

I want to say that it did. That is what people want to hear. It did not help. The roof was too heavy. The roof was the house my father built, when I carried the water in a tin cup.

But she turned. It was the last thing she did, and it was the right thing, and it did not help, and I am proud of her for it until I die.

—

They were washed by the women in my cousin's house, because there was no house of ours anymore, and wrapped in the *kafan* [ka-FAN], the plain white cloth every one of us goes into the earth in, rich or poor, so that we all go looking the same.

Laila was wrapped in a long one.

Parisa was wrapped in a small one.

I carried her. They tried to stop me, because my left arm was broken and the bone was pushing against the skin where bones should not push. But I carried her in my right arm. She had been too heavy to carry, the night before, when Laila took her down the stairs. Now she weighed nothing. A child in a *kafan* weighs nothing. It is as if the cloth is empty, and you are only carrying the idea of a child.

We walked to the graveyard on the hill outside the town, where my father is, and my mother. A long line of men in the afternoon heat with the dust still in our hair. The women stayed behind, as is our custom, and their crying followed us up the hill like a wind.

—

I saw the young man.

The one with the cracked Samsung. The one who laughed with his whole face.

He stood alone at the edge of the graveyard, by the wall, with his clean hands folded in front of him, and watched us lower them into

the ground, the long white shape and then the small one. When the first earth went in, he turned and walked away down the hill.

I never saw him again.

I do not know why he came. Maybe because he heard that the man who fixed telephones had lost his family, and he was a polite young man who had once given the girl a sweet. Maybe because he knew exactly why the sky had fallen on my roof, and could not stay away. Maybe both.

His telephone was under my house, under the bricks, with the others. I never went back for it.

—

The birds came home that evening.

Wahid's boy came running to tell me. *Kaka* [KAA-kaa], *Uncle Nasim, your birds are back. They are on your house.*

So I walked back through the town in the blue hour, with my arm tied against my chest in a scarf.

The blue door lay in the street, blown off its hinges. I stepped over it. It did not stick anymore. Nothing sticks anymore.

And on the edge of the roof that was left, the west side, in a row, were my birds.

Nineteen of them. Three were never found, and Uncle was one of them. I looked for him for weeks. I never found a feather.

But nineteen had come down out of the sky to the roof where they always came, and there was no loft for them, and no man in the middle of the roof to whistle them in. So they had landed on the edge, in a row, where the telephones used to sit, and they were waiting.

They looked down at me with their orange eyes.

Is it time?

I sat down in the courtyard, under what was left of the tree, in the dust, and looked up at them, and they looked down at me.

And above them, high and thin and patient, was the sound.

It had stayed. All day, while we dug, while we washed them, while we carried them up the hill, it had been there, going around and around, watching.

I did not nod to it. I did not say good morning.

I only looked up at it, for the first time in my life, the way it had always believed I was looking. As if I knew exactly what it was.

INTERLUDE TWO • 1907-1923

A Short History of Watching from Above

The Pharmacist's Pigeons

This is a true story. It is about how seeing from the sky turned into striking from the sky, how quickly it happened, and how the rules meant to protect the people underneath always seem to arrive after the funeral.

In the small German town of Kronberg [KRON-berg], in the hills above Frankfurt, a pharmacist named Julius Neubronner [NOY-bron-er] kept pigeons for his work. They were homing pigeons. A homing pigeon always flies home, however far away you take it. Let one go at a hospital in the next town with a prescription tied to its leg, and it flies straight back to the pharmacy. The birds did not care what they carried. They only wanted to go home.

One day a pigeon was lost in the fog and did not come back for four weeks. Neubronner wondered where it had been. And he had an idea: what if a pigeon could take a picture?

He built a tiny camera of wood and metal, light enough for a bird to carry, with a little clock inside that opened the shutter by itself while the bird was in the air. He strapped it to the bird's chest with a small harness, like a waistcoat, and let the birds go. When they came home, he had something almost no one had seen before: the world as a bird sees it. Rooftops from above. Streets with tiny people in them who had no idea they were being photographed. At the edge of some pictures, a blurred gray shape: the tip of the bird's own wing.

He applied for a patent in 1907. People bought the photographs as postcards. They were charmed.

The army saw something else. A camera that could fly over the enemy with no man in it. A spy that could not be questioned if it was caught. When the Great War came, camera pigeons were tried over its battlefields.

Neubronner had only wanted to know where his lost bird had been.

Four years after his patent, in November 1911, Italy was fighting a war in the desert of Libya. Its few new airplanes, flimsy things of wood and cloth, were used at first only to look.

Then one morning a young Italian pilot named Giulio Gavotti [JOO-lee-oh ga-VOT-tee] flew over an enemy camp at an oasis with four small bombs in a leather bag on his lap, not much bigger than oranges. He leaned over the side of his plane and dropped one. It was the first bomb ever dropped from an airplane. That evening he wrote to his father about it. He was excited. He did not know whether he had hit anyone.

Four years. That is how long it took, from a pigeon's picture of a rooftop to a bomb falling on people who could not see it coming.

After that it went very fast. Within a few years, airplanes and airships were bombing London and Paris, and towns where the people underneath were bakers and seamstresses and children. When that war ended, the governments of the world sent lawyers to The Hague, in Holland, to write rules for war from the air.

In 1923 they wrote them down. Bombing to terrify ordinary people was forbidden. A bomb could only be dropped on a military target. If a pilot could not tell whether a target was military, he must not drop the bomb.

They were good rules, written by serious people who had seen what happened to London.

And no country ever agreed to them. Not one. They were printed and put on a shelf, a promise that nobody made.

What is a rule worth, if no one has to follow it? What is a promise worth, if it comes after the bomb has fallen? And when it comes that late, who is it really for: the people underneath, or the people who need to sleep at night?

Some of Neubronner's photographs are not like the others. They are tilted, because the bird was turning when the shutter opened, and they show a rooftop very close, rushing up, with the blurred gray tip of a wing at the edge.

Look at one long enough and it becomes a picture of the bird coming home. You can almost see what it saw. The roof, getting bigger. The little door of the loft. The man standing there with grain in his hand. The thing it had flown toward the whole time, through the fog and the cold, with a camera strapped to its chest that it did not understand, taking pictures of a world it did not care about.

It only wanted to go home.

It did not know what it was carrying. It never does.

III. THE FORTIETH DAY

THIRTEEN • Nasim

The envelope came on the twenty-third day.

I counted the days the way grief counts them, which is in nights. Twenty-three times I had lain down on the half of the roof that was left, among the nineteen birds, and closed my eyes, and opened them again, and found that it was still true.

A boy came from the governor's compound with a paper. The Americans wished to see me. Tomorrow, at ten.

I knew why. By then, in our country, everyone knew someone it had happened to. There were always two things that came after. First the silence. Then the envelope.

—

I put on my good clothes, the ones I had worn to my wedding, which Wahid's wife had found in a trunk of things saved from the house. The shirt was too big now. I tied my broken arm in a clean scarf and walked through the bazaar, past my shop. The shutter was down. Someone had written on it in chalk, in a child's hand, *God is great*, and under it, in a different hand, *the telephone man's family*, and nothing else, as if whoever wrote it had not known how to finish the sentence.

They took me to a room with a long table, plastic chairs, a picture of the President on the wall, and an air conditioner in the window that roared like a lion and made the room as cold as the inside of a well.

There was an American at the table, younger than me, in the tan uniform, with a clean, careful face. He stood up when I came in. That surprised me. He put his hand on his heart, the way we do, and said in bad Dari [da-REE], our language, *salaam alaikum* [sa-LAAM a-LAY-kum], peace be upon you, which he had clearly learned for this. Beside him sat an interpreter from Kabul with a pen behind his ear.

The American spoke for a long time, and the interpreter put it into Dari. I remember every word. I have the paper still.

The government of the United States was deeply sorry for the loss of my wife and daughter. On the morning of the strike, American forces had believed they were acting against a person who was a

threat to the people of Afghanistan and to American soldiers. Afterwards the matter had been looked into carefully, and it had been found that I was not that person. A mistake had been made. A tragic mistake. They wished to express their sympathy.

The interpreter said *a tragic mistake* in English first, before he said it in Dari, as if he wanted me to hear how the words sounded in their own language.

Then the American took a thick white envelope out of a folder and pushed it across the table to me with two fingers, gently, the way you push a cup of tea toward a guest.

—

I did not touch it.

The interpreter leaned toward me and said quietly, not translating, just a man talking to a man, “Brother. Open it here. Then they can write that you opened it.”

It was money. American dollars, new ones, in a paper band. And a sheet of paper, in English and in Dari, with a place at the bottom for a signature.

My hands counted the money before my heart knew what it was holding. I have kept a shop for twenty years. When someone gives you money, your hands count it.

Four thousand dollars.

My hands had counted it into two piles on the table without asking me. Two thousand for Laila. Two thousand for Parisa. Perhaps they meant it as one sum, for the house, for the arm. But there they were. Two piles. One for a woman of thirty-eight who sewed dresses and made up proverbs. One for a girl of eight who counted screws in the lid of a jam jar.

The same size. I remember that the most. Someone had decided that a child was worth the same as her mother. I did not know if that was a kindness or the opposite of one.

—

The interpreter read me the paper slowly, with his finger under the words, though I can read. I let him. I wanted to hear it in a voice.

The money was a condolence payment, given *ex gratia* [eks GRAY-shee-uh].

"What does that mean?"

"It is Latin," he said. "It means *from kindness*. It means they are not giving it because they have to. They are giving it because they want to."

The next line said the payment was not an admission of responsibility, and did not mean that the United States owed me anything under any law.

"So it is a gift," I said.

The interpreter did not answer.

"They kill my wife and my child, and they give me a gift."

He said something to the American in English. Perhaps he translated me. Perhaps he softened it. The American's face changed a little, the way a lake changes when a cloud goes over it, and he said something short.

"He says he is very sorry," the interpreter said. "He says he has a daughter too."

—

I signed the paper.

People in America have asked me why, people with kind faces and notebooks, as if a man with a broken arm and no house and no family, in a cold room under a picture of the President, had a choice.

But that is not the real answer. The real answer is that I understood, sitting there, that the paper was not for me. It was for them. It was so that somewhere, in some office far away, a man could put it in a folder and close the folder and say: *it is finished*. And I thought: let it be finished for them, then. It will never be finished for me. Let somebody have that.

That was my kindness. My *ex gratia*.

When I stood, the American stood too, and put out his hand. I want to tell you I left it in the air. That would be a better story.

I took it. His hand was cold from the air conditioner, and it held mine a little too long.

I walked out into the heat of the day, which was like stepping into a bath, with four thousand dollars in my good shirt, and I did not know where home was, so I walked to the ruin. And that afternoon I did a thing I am ashamed of, and not ashamed of at all. I went to the bazaar and bought grain. The best grain, wheat and corn and the yellow lentils, more than they could eat in a month, and I carried it up the stairs that were left and poured it out for my birds onto the bricks, a golden hill of it, and sat and watched them eat.

From kindness, I said to them.

They did not care where it came from. They are birds.

FOURTEEN • Kayla

They interviewed me twice.

It's called a commander-directed investigation. An officer who wasn't involved asks everybody what happened and writes a report, and a commander decides if anybody did anything wrong. It's not a court. You sit in a room with a fake plant in the corner and a box of Kleenex nobody touches, and a major you've never met asks you questions in a voice like a dentist.

The first time, he had my log, all forty-one days of it, with yellow sticky tabs coming out the side like feathers. He read me the line from day thirty-three, out loud: *Subject on roof. Looks up at aircraft at dawn, daily. Possible awareness of surveillance.*

"What did you mean by that?"

"I meant he looked up. Every morning."

"At the aircraft."

"At the sky."

"You wrote *aircraft*."

"I know what I wrote."

—

The second time was a month later. Same plant. Same Kleenex. He slid a printout across the table.

"I thought you should see this before the report goes up," he said, and it was the only kind thing he ever said to me.

It was what they'd found when they went back and looked at everything again. Not the pieces that made the picture. The pieces we'd walked past. It was written plainly, like a weather report.

The man on the roof was not the facilitator. He was a phone repairman with a shop in the bazaar, with no known connection to any armed group. The phone belonged to a customer who had left it with him for repair several times. He tested phones on the roof because the signal was better there. The visitors were customers and neighbors. The sacks were bird feed. The structure on the roof was a pigeon loft.

The repairman kept pigeons.

He looked up at the sky because he was watching his birds.

—

"So it was all wrong," I said.

"It wasn't all wrong," the major said. "The selector was real. The phone was there. It just wasn't his."

"So we were trying to kill a phone."

He didn't answer that. He told me what the report would say, picking his words like a man crossing a creek on stones. The strike was conducted within the rules of engagement. The target was positively identified, based on the information available at the time. The information turned out to be wrong. An error in the final seconds of terminal guidance moved the point of impact. No negligence or misconduct by any individual.

"Terminal guidance," I said. "That's me."

"That's the system."

"That's my hand."

"That's the system, Sergeant."

Here's the math I did that night, at the kitchen table at four in the morning, with a glass of my mother's boxed wine and the fan going.

If I'd held the box on him. If I'd been faster than the lag. If the bird hadn't come down, if the girl hadn't shouted, if he hadn't turned.

The missile would have hit him on the roof, alone. The wife and the girl would have been in the east room, outside the circle, alive. Good effects. The pilot would have finished his sandwich.

And the man on the roof would have been a phone repairman who kept pigeons.

You understand? There was no version of that morning where I did my job perfectly and nobody innocent died. The only version where nobody innocent died was the one where the missile never left the rail, and that was decided a long way up, by people reading my log.

So which is it? Is it my fault, because my hand moved the box onto his family? Or not my fault, because if my hand had been perfect I'd have killed an innocent man instead, and that would have been *the system working*? Is a perfect shot at the wrong man better or worse than a bad one? Is one dead innocent better than two?

I sat at the table till the sky went gray and couldn't answer it. I've thought about it every day for three years. I still can't tell you which one I would rather have done.

Something else I found out later. In 2013 the President put out a rule for strikes like ours. Before a lethal strike there had to be *near certainty* the target was there, and *near certainty* no civilians would be hurt. The White House called it the highest standard it could set. I remember feeling proud of it, in tech school.

What I didn't know was that it only applied outside what they called *areas of active hostilities*. Afghanistan was an area of active hostilities. So in the real war, the rule didn't apply. Not to us. Not to the house in Maidan Shahr.

I read that on my phone in a Starbucks two years too late. I'm not saying it would have saved them. Maybe no rule in the world would

have caught the pigeons. But it would have been nice to know the highest standard we could set had been set.

The pilot didn't sit at any kitchen table at four in the morning. I want to be fair to him. He's not a villain in this. Nobody is. That's the whole problem.

I asked him the week after the second interview, in the box, at three in the morning, watching a road in Helmand [hel-MAND] where nothing was happening.

"Do you think about it."

He chewed for a while. "Sure."

"How do you sleep."

He was an honest man. He gave it real thought.

"Kayla. We did everything right. The process worked. The inputs were bad. That's on whoever built the picture. If you start carrying the inputs, you'll never put anything down again."

"I built the picture."

"You fed it. Lots of people fed it. Twenty people read that line and signed off. You think you're the only one who should've caught it?" He shook his head. "That's ego. Thinking it's all yours."

Then he told me he'd taken his girls to Lake Mead on Saturday, and Lacey had caught an eleven-pound striped bass and screamed the whole time she was reeling it in. He smiled, a real smile. "Bring Wyatt out sometime."

And I thought: he's not pretending. He really did watch his daughter scream with joy at an eleven-pound fish, and it really was wonderful, and he really did kill a woman and a child in Maidan Shahr six weeks before. He holds both. It doesn't break him.

And I could not tell you which one of us was the sick one.

—

The base had a psychologist with an office right in the building. The Air Force had surveyed about a thousand of us, I found out later. Most were fine. Proud of the work, proud of protecting the guys on the ground. A small number had real post-traumatic stress. A lot more were just burned out, from the nights and the twelve-hour shifts and living two lives.

She gave me a form with seventeen questions. *Repeated, disturbing memories. Trouble falling asleep. Feeling cut off from other people.* I gave myself mostly twos. *A little bit.*

She looked at the form and then at me.

"There's a term we use now. Moral injury." She put the form down. "Post-traumatic stress is usually about fear. But you were never in danger. Nobody shot at you. Moral injury is when you do something, or fail to stop something, that goes against what you believe is right. It's not that you're scared. It's that you can't make it fit with who you thought you were."

"So what's the treatment," I said.

She was quiet for a second.

"We're still working on that."

FIFTEEN • Nasim

On the fortieth day, we did the *chehlom* [CHEH-lum].

In our tradition, the first forty days after a death are the days of mourning. People come to sit with you. The Holy Book is read through, all of it, by men who come in turns. And on the fortieth day everyone gathers one last time, and there is food, and prayer, and then, they say, the first part of the grief is over. The soul has gone on. The family can begin to live again.

That is what they say.

I will tell it slowly, because it was slow. It was the longest day of my life. The day of the strike was a moment. The fortieth day was a mountain.

—

I woke on the roof before dawn, as I always did.

The birds lived in the open now, on the half of the roof that was left, under a sheet of blue plastic stretched between two broken timbers. I had not built them a new loft. I did not have it in me. They slept in a row along the edge, where the telephones had been.

I lay there and listened to them, and did not open my eyes.

That is the first thing about grief that no one tells you. The waking. Every morning, for one moment, you do not remember. Your body wakes before your memory does, and your body is happy. It is warm, it has slept, the birds are talking. For half a breath you are the man you were. And then your memory comes into the room and sits down on your chest.

Every morning. Forty mornings. It never once failed to come.

—

I went down the stairs that were left.

Wahid's wife and the women of the street had swept the courtyard every day since, as if dust could be made to understand it was not welcome. The mulberry tree had been cut back where its branches were broken. It looked like a man with his sleeves rolled up.

And here is what I did. I want to tell you exactly.

Wahid had set up a small gas ring for me on a stone. I lit it, and boiled the kettle, and made green tea.

And I set out three cups.

I did not decide to. My hands did it. They took three small glass cups from the shelf and set them on the tray in a row, the way they had every morning for eight years. One for me, one for Laila, and a small one for Parisa, with only a little tea and a lot of sugar. I poured the tea into all three, and sat down on the step, and looked at the tray.

Three cups.

Two of them going cold.

I did that every morning. Forty mornings. Wahid's wife saw me do it once and said nothing, and the next day she brought a fresh packet of sugar and set it beside the tray and went away. She understood. Some things you cannot stop your hands from doing. You can only make sure there is sugar.

The men came at nine to read.

They came through the gap where the blue door had been. Old men from the mosque, young men from the bazaar, men I had fixed radios for. They sat on carpets in the shade of the cut-back tree and took the Holy Book in turns, reading in the old language in a low voice that rose and fell like water over stones.

I sat with them. I could not read. My mouth would not make the words.

And while they read, I heard her.

I want to be careful telling you this. I am not a madman. I am a man who fixes radios. I know the difference between a sound and a memory. But there are things in grief that are neither. You can decide what to call them.

The first was the stairs.

In the middle of a verse, I heard someone coming up the outside stairs. *Slap. Slap. Slap.* Small feet. Plastic sandals on cold brick. Slow, the way she came up in the mornings when she was still sleepy.

I turned my head.

There was no one on the stairs.

I knew there was no one before I turned. I turned anyway. It is not that you believe she is there. It is that some part of you older than believing, a part that was built to listen for her and has never been told to stop, turns your head for you. And you let it. Because the alternative is to tell that part of you it can stop listening, and you will not. You would rather turn your head a thousand times to an empty staircase than once tell yourself you do not need to.

I turned my head eleven times that morning. I counted, after.

At noon the women brought the food. Rice with raisins and carrots, and the *halwa* [HAL-wa], the sweet of flour and butter and sugar that is always made for the dead, because the old women say the dead are hungry for sweetness, and the smell reaches them. The whole courtyard smelled of butter and cardamom. It was the smell of every funeral of my life, and every wedding, because they are the same smell.

I sat with a plate on my knees and did not eat.

And Laila said, quite clearly, in my ear: *Nasim. Eat something. You look like a broom.*

That was the second thing. Her voice. Not a whisper from the grave. Her ordinary voice, the one she used in the kitchen, a little impatient, a little amused. It was a thing she said, when I was thin from a fever, or worked too late at the shop.

I knew it was my own mind, holding her voice the way you turn a coin over in your pocket because it is the only one you have left.

I ate a spoonful of rice.

Good, she said.

And I put the spoon down and put my face in my good hand, and the men around me went quiet, and an old man I did not know put his hand on the back of my neck and kept it there, very still, while I made a sound I had not made since I was a child.

In the afternoon the mullah [MUL-la], the man who leads the prayers at our mosque, said what is said. That a child who dies before she is grown goes straight to Paradise and waits at the gate for her parents, to take them by the hand and lead them in. He said Parisa would be the first face I saw.

People wept. It is a beautiful thing to say. It has been said in our country for a thousand years, at the graves of a thousand thousand children.

I sat and listened, and I thought: *she will be waiting in her sandals.*

That was all I could think. Both of them. One on her foot and one in her hand. She will hold it up when she sees me at the gate, and say, *Baba, I found it.*

And I will not be able to say *show me*. Because I will already have seen.

—

By evening everyone had gone. Wahid embraced me at the gap where the door had been and said, *Sleep at my house tonight, at least tonight*, and I said no.

It was the fortieth night. They say that for forty days the soul stays near the people it loved, and on the fortieth night it rises and goes on.

I lay down on the half of the roof that was left, under the stars, among my birds.

And the sound was there.

It had never gone away. I do not know if it was the same one, or if the people who fly them go home at night. I only know it had watched every one of the forty days. It had watched us dig, and wash them, and carry them up the hill. It had watched me set out three cups every morning. It had watched me turn my head to the empty stairs eleven times.

It knew more about my grief than anyone.

—

That night I dreamed for the first time since the strike.

I was on the roof, the whole roof, the way it was. The loft was there, with Uncle in it. It was dawn, the color that has no name.

And Laila came up the stairs with Parisa behind her in her sandals, and they stood at the top of the stairs, at the place where I had stood when the light came out of the bricks. They were not hurt. They were exactly as they were. Laila had flour on her hands. Parisa had sleep in her eyes.

"Nasim," Laila said, "come down. Breakfast is ready."

"Come down, Baba. The tea's getting cold."

"In a minute," I said. "I am waiting for the birds."

Laila smiled at me the way she smiled when I was being a *kaftar-baz*, the smile that meant she knew exactly what I was and had decided to love it anyway.

"They'll come home," she said. "They always come home. Come and eat."

"In a minute," I said.

And they turned and went down the stairs, *slap, slap, slap*, and I heard the door stick and then give, and I heard Laila set the cups on the tray, one, two, three.

And I stood on the roof and looked up at the sky, waiting for my birds.

And I did not go down.

—

I woke with my face wet and the stars going out.

This is the part I have never told anyone. Not Wahid. Not the doctor with the soft voice who asked me, years later, in a small white room, whether I ever thought about hurting myself.

When I woke, I was angry. Not at the Americans. Not at God. At myself, in the dream, for saying *in a minute*. They had come up the stairs to fetch me, with flour on their hands, and I had stayed on the roof to wait for birds.

And then I understood that it was not a dream about them. It was a dream about what I did every morning for eight years. Every morning they called me down to breakfast, and every morning I said *in a minute*, and stayed on the roof with my face turned up.

That was why I was on the roof. That was why I was alive.

Because I was a *kaftar-baz*. A man who looked at the sky when he should have been looking at his family.

And they were in the house, where a man should be.

SIXTEEN • Kayla

It started with the coffee.

About three weeks after the strike, I was on shift, and I'd put a big 7-Eleven coffee on the console next to the joystick and forgotten it. Around two in the morning I looked down at it.

And I saw it cooling.

Not *oh, my coffee's cold*. I saw it. I looked at the paper cup and saw the heat in it, a bright white disc at the top, a thin wavering thread of white rising out of the hole in the lid, and the whole thing, so slowly you'd never see it if you looked away, getting dimmer. White to a little less white. A little less white to the gray of a cloud.

I sat there for forty minutes watching a cup of coffee cool. The pilot said something to me twice and I didn't hear him. When I finally drank it, it tasted like nothing, and I thought: *there. It's dead now.*

That's when I knew something was wrong with me.

I'm not telling you I got superpowers. My eyes are regular eyes. I'm telling you that after two years of twelve-hour nights looking at a world made of heat, and then that morning, and then the nineteen minutes, my brain started doing it on its own. Like when you play Tetris too long and close your eyes and the blocks keep falling. Your brain learns a way of seeing, and then it won't let go.

Mine learned heat.

It got worse the way water gets into a basement. At the grocery store I'd look at the cashier's hands going back and forth over the scanner and see two little lamps. The people behind me in line, a string of candles, like a procession.

I stopped buying hot food. It sounds like nothing. I stopped going to Panda Express, which Wyatt loved, because I couldn't sit there with the orange chicken steaming on the plate and know I'd watch it go from white to gray the whole meal and not taste any of it. I ate cold things. Salads. Yogurt. I lost eleven pounds. My mother said I looked good.

—

And at night.

Every night I wasn't on shift, I went into Wyatt's room and stood in the doorway with the hall light behind me, and I counted him.

One. A white shape under the rocket-ship blanket. A big lamp. Warm.

And I'd stand there and watch to make sure he stayed white.

That's the part I can't explain to anyone who hasn't done the job. I could hear him breathing. I could see his chest go up and down. But the part of me that sat in the box for two years didn't trust breathing. It trusted only heat. So I'd stand in the doorway long enough to be sure he wasn't fading, and that if he was, I'd see it. Some nights an hour.

One night that winter he had a fever. A hundred and two. He was hot as a stove. And I stood in his doorway at four in the morning and couldn't tell if he was too hot or just hot. My brain kept saying *white means warm, warm means alive*, and he was the warmest he'd ever been, and some broken part of me looked at him burning up in his little bed and thought: *good. He's so alive.*

I didn't give him Tylenol till six. I sat in the doorway till six, watching him glow, because he looked so alive.

The fever broke on its own. He was fine. He was always fine.

I've never told anyone that. That's the worst thing in this book that I did on purpose.

—

I lasted another year and a half like that, counting him. Then, in the spring of 2021, I put in my papers. Nobody tried very hard to stop me. My record was clean. The investigation had found no misconduct. On paper I was exactly what I'd been before.

The pilot gave me a card his wife had picked out, a sunset with *Wishing You Peace on Your Journey* in gold letters. Inside he'd written: *An honor to fly with you. Lake Mead invitation stands. Bring the kid.* It's in a drawer.

On the drive home from the base for the last time, the sun was in front of me and the desert was the color of a lion, and I thought: *that's it. You're out.*

And I thought: *you're never out.*

A month later I got a job in the surveillance room of a casino on the Strip. Watching cameras. Night shift. It was the only thing I knew how to do.

SEVENTEEN • Nasim

After the fortieth day, I went back to the shop, because Wahid's wife told me, gently, that a man who does not work will soon be dead or mad, and I had not decided yet which I wanted to be.

The people came slowly. They brought me their broken telephones and did not look me in the eye, and then, after a few weeks, they did. They talked about the price of flour and whose son was getting married. They did not talk about the roof. It was as if the whole town had agreed, without speaking, to give me the gift of an ordinary day.

I fixed telephones. I did not take them home anymore.

—

The two years after are not a story. They are only time.

I lived in the two rooms on the west side that still stood, behind a new tin door that does not stick. I built the birds a small loft on the half of the roof that was left and flew them every morning. I had told myself I would stop. I could not. My body went up the stairs at dawn the way it always had. But I did not look up at the sound anymore. When it was there, I looked at the birds.

The war came closer. The men in the trucks with the white flags came down out of the mountains into the valleys, and then into the towns. The Americans were leaving; they had made an agreement with the men in the trucks. Everyone knew how it would end. No one said it. It was like the sound in the sky.

I did not care who won. I had nothing left for either side to take.

In the middle of August 2021, Maidan Shahr fell.

It was not dramatic. There was some shooting at night. In the morning the soldiers on the walls of the governor's compound were gone, and different men sat on the walls with their legs over the edge, with long hair and white flags and Kalashnikovs, eating apricots. The town woke up and belonged to someone else. By evening, Kabul had fallen too.

That afternoon, my telephone rang.

A foreign woman, with an interpreter on the line. She worked for an organization that kept records of civilians harmed in the war. Because the Americans had admitted the strike was a mistake, my name was on a list of people they had agreed to help leave the country.

"Why?" I said.

"She says it is part of making amends," the interpreter said. "Making it right."

I looked out at the street, where a boy with a Kalashnikov taller than he was stood eating a melon and spitting the seeds into the gutter.

"How do you make it right?" I said.

The interpreter did not translate that. He said, "Brother. Do you want to go or not? There is not much time."

I did not think about it long. My wife and daughter were on the hill, and would be on the hill whether I was in Maidan Shahr or on the moon. And the men on the walls were the same men who, the last time they ruled, had banned the flying of pigeons, saying it wasted time and took a man's eyes from God. They went from roof to roof, opening the lofts and killing the birds. I was young then. I hid three of my father's best birds in a crate in the cellar for five years and fed them by candlelight.

I did not think I had five more years of candlelight in me.

"Yes," I said.

—

The night before I left, I let the birds go.

You cannot take nineteen birds through an airport with men with guns at every gate. So I opened the loft in the dark, which you must never do, and took them out one by one, and held each one against my chest a moment and felt the hum of its heart, and threw it up into the night. They did not understand. Birds do not fly in the dark. They fluttered up and came down again, confused, on the wall, on the cut-back tree, and sat there and looked at me. *Is it time?*

All but one.

A young gray bird with a white collar, the son of Uncle, hatched in the loft the spring before the strike. I had not been able to name him. But he had Uncle's collar and Uncle's orange eye, and Uncle's way of landing on my hand on the good days.

I put him in a shoebox, from a pair of school shoes I had bought for Parisa in Kabul, which she never wore because she would only wear her sandals. I cut holes in the lid with my father's soldering iron and put a little grain in the corner.

In the morning I walked out of Maidan Shahr in my good shirt, the one I was married in, with the shoebox under my good arm and nothing else.

—

The airport was hell. You have seen it. Everyone saw it. The crowds at the gates. The sewage canal where people stood to their waists in filth, holding up their papers. The children passed over the walls from hand to hand. The young men who held onto the wheels of the airplane as it took off, and fell.

I was there for three days. I stood in the canal with the shoebox held over my head and my papers in my teeth. When people pushed, I held it higher. Sometimes I felt a small shift of weight, a scratch of claws on cardboard. That was how I knew he was still alive.

On the third day a young American soldier with a sunburned face found my name on his list and waved me through.

Then he saw the box.

"What's in that?"

"A pigeon."

He looked at me. He looked at the crowd behind me, the thousands, the dust, the children being handed over the wall.

"Sir, I can't let you take a live animal on the plane. I'm sorry. You have to leave it."

—

I stood at the gate of Kabul airport with the shoebox in my hands.

I had carried it three days through hell. It was the last thing in the world that was mine, that knew my whistle, that would land on my hand.

So I opened the lid.

The bird looked up at me with Uncle's orange eye, dusty and thin and frightened.

Is it time?

"Yes," I said. "It's time."

I held him against my chest and felt the hum of his heart, and threw him up, high, over the gate and the wire and the crowds, into the hot white sky over Kabul.

He went up in a circle, wider and higher, the way they do. He circled the airport once, twice, a small gray flicker in the white. And I stood at the gate with the empty box and my head back, the way I have stood every morning of my life, and watched him.

And then he turned.

He turned west. Toward the mountains. Toward Wardak, and a town called Maidan Shahr, an hour away if the road is good, and a ruined house with half a roof and a loft made of fruit crates.

He was going home.

A homing pigeon always goes home. It does not matter how far you take it, or what has happened there, or that there is no one left to whistle it down. It goes home.

I watched him until he was a grain of salt.

Then the soldier touched my arm, gently. "Sir. You have to go."

I got on the airplane with an empty shoebox. I have it still. It is the only thing I brought from my country. Inside, in the corner, there is a little grain, and a single gray feather.

EIGHTEEN • Kayla

I watched it on TV like everybody else.

August 2021. I worked nights at the casino by then, so I watched in the mornings, on the couch, with the sound low so I wouldn't wake Wyatt, who was nine now. The crowds at the airport. The canal. The C-17 taking off with people running alongside it, and the dots falling off it into the air.

I watched it the way I used to watch the house. Zoomed in. Looking for one man.

I knew it was stupid. There were a hundred thousand people at that airport and I had never seen his face. Only the top of his head, and his shoulders, the right one a little lower than the left, and the way he walked. But I looked. Every crowd shot. Every face in the canal.

I never saw him. I didn't expect to. I just couldn't stop looking.

—

On the twenty-sixth of August, a suicide bomber blew himself up at an airport gate. Thirteen American service members died, and more than a hundred and seventy Afghans.

Three days later, on the twenty-ninth, the United States launched one last drone strike before the last plane left. In Kabul. On a white car in a courtyard. They said it was full of explosives. A *righteous strike*, someone called it.

Two weeks later the *New York Times* went to the house.

The man in the car was an aid worker for an American charity. He'd spent the day driving around Kabul, picking up colleagues and filling water containers, because the water was out in his neighborhood. The things they'd watched him load into the car were water jugs. When he pulled into his courtyard at the end of the

day, the children of his family ran out to meet him and climbed in to ride the last few feet, the way kids do.

Ten people died. Seven of them were children.

The Pentagon called it a tragic mistake. The Air Force inspector general said it was caused by execution errors, by people reading information in a way that supported what they already believed, and by people not talking to each other. Nobody broke any law. Nobody was negligent. In December, the Secretary of Defense decided no one would be punished. They offered the family condolence payments, and help to leave Afghanistan.

—

I read every article, at four in the morning in the casino break room, with the slot machines dinging through the wall like a thousand tiny church bells.

Confirmation bias.

I read those two words twenty times. And I wrote down the name of a reporter who had covered it, a woman at a newspaper in New York. I didn't know yet what I'd do with it.

That was me. That was my log. That was the pigeons going into the picture, and the sacks, and the phones on the wall, and the man looking up. The same mistake, two years later, in a different city, with different people in the box. It wasn't a new mistake. It was the mistake the system was built to make.

And again nobody was punished.

At least the family is going to get out, I thought.

And then I thought about the house in Maidan Shahr. About whether anybody had put his name on a list.

And I thought: *if they did, where would they send him?*

—

The pilot texted me that week. *Brutal what's happening over there. Glad we're out of it.* And a minute later: *Lacey made the varsity softball team,* with a picture of a girl in a uniform, grinning, holding a bat. She had his smile.

I typed: *Congrats to her*. I deleted it.

I typed: *Do you ever think about the girl in the east room*.

I deleted that too.

I put the phone face down and went back to my chair in the surveillance room, where forty screens showed forty views of the casino floor, and a thousand people, in black and white, pulled a thousand levers and waited for something to come down.

INTERLUDE THREE • 1937-1977

A Short History of Watching from Above

Who Counts as a Civilian

This is a true story. It is about the long effort, after the bombing of cities, to write down who must not be killed in war, and how many deaths are too many. It is about the two rules that should have protected the house in Maidan Shahr, and what those rules actually say.

—

On a Monday afternoon in April 1937, it was market day in the small Basque town of Guernica [ger-NEE-ka], in northern Spain. Spain was at war with itself, and the general on one side had friends in Germany and Italy who wanted to try out their new airplanes.

At about half past four, the bombers came. They came in waves for more than three hours: heavy bombs to knock the buildings down, then fire bombs to burn the ruins, then fighters flying low to shoot the people running into the fields. Most of Guernica was destroyed. How many died is still argued about. The town had almost no soldiers in it at all.

What made Guernica different was that the world saw it. Reporters walked through the ruins the next morning and wrote about it for London and New York. A Spanish painter in Paris painted it in black and white and gray: a screaming horse, a mother holding a dead child, a light bulb like an eye. For the first time, ordinary people far away understood what it meant that a town of people who were fighting no one could be killed by men they never saw, who flew home afterwards and ate dinner.

Then came the Second World War, and Guernica was only the beginning. Every side bombed cities, on purpose: Warsaw, London, Hamburg, Dresden, Tokyo, and at the end two Japanese cities, each destroyed by a single bomb. Tens of millions died, a great many of them in their own houses, under their own roofs.

After that, the world tried again to write rules. It took until 1977. That year the nations agreed to add new rules to the Geneva Conventions, and two of them are the ones that matter for this book. Kayla was taught them in the schoolhouse. They are simple to say and very hard to do.

The first is **distinction**. In war, you must always tell soldiers from civilians. You may attack soldiers and the things an army fights with. You may not attack people who are not fighting, or their homes, schools and markets. And if you are not sure whether a person is a soldier or a civilian, you must treat them as a civilian.

The second is **proportionality**. Even when you attack a real military target, you must think about the ordinary people nearby. If the harm to them would be *excessive*, too much compared with what you expect to gain, you must not attack.

Excessive. The whole rule rests on that word.

It does not say you may never kill a civilian. It says you may not kill *too many*, compared with what you gain. It is a pair of scales, with the people who might die on one side and the value of the target on the other, and some officer in some room has to weigh them. How much is a facilitator's phone worth? How many sleeping people in an east room are too many? Is one? Is two?

The rule does not say. It cannot. It leaves that to the people with their hands on the scales.

The United States signed those 1977 rules, but it never ratified them, which means it never made them binding through its own government. Yet it says it follows distinction and proportionality anyway, because they are older than any treaty, and its military teaches them, and its lawyers check strikes against them.

So the rules that should have protected Laila and Parisa were there. They were taught. They were followed. The strike that killed them was checked against them, and found to be within them.

A mistake, they said. Not a crime.

On the day after the bombing of Guernica, a woman sat in the ashes of what had been her house. Nobody wrote down her name. There were too many like her. She sat with her arms around her knees and did not cry, and did not move when the men came with carts for the dead.

Nobody asked her whether her loss had been proportional. Nobody brought her a pair of scales and asked her to weigh her children against a bridge, or a road, or a phone.

Forty years later, careful people in a beautiful room in Geneva argued for years over one word. They found it, and wrote it down, and it has saved lives.

But not one of them went to Guernica and asked the woman in the ashes what it should be.

The law had found a word for how much grief was allowed.

It never asked the grieving.

IV. DESERT INN

NINETEEN • Nasim

In America, the first thing they gave me was a bracelet.

A white paper bracelet with a number on it, which a woman in a uniform put around my wrist on the airplane in Qatar, the way they put a bracelet on a newborn so that nobody takes the wrong baby home. I wore it for two months. I did not take it off to wash. I was afraid that if I took it off, I would no longer be anyone.

They flew us to a military base in the desert of New Mexico, a place called Holloman [HOL-o-man], and put us in great white tents in rows, with cots in rows, and on every folded gray blanket a small bag with a toothbrush and a comb. An old man from Logar [lo-GAR], a province south of Kabul, sat on the next cot with one eye clouded white. *They are very organized*, he said. *They are always very organized*. We both understood what he meant, and neither of us said it.

Two months of waiting. The nights were cold and the stars were very close, and I lay on my cot and listened.

There was no sound in that sky. No buzzing. No patient going around and around. I did not sleep well without it. That is a strange thing to tell you, and it is true. For two years I had slept under the sound. Now the silence was too big, and I lay awake in it like a man who has lived beside a river all his life and moves to the desert and cannot sleep for the quiet.

—

In the autumn a woman with a lanyard full of keys came to the tent and said I was going to a city called Las Vegas. Jobs, she said. Hotels. Casinos.

“What is a casino?”

“A house of gambling,” the interpreter said in Dari. “Very big. They play cards for money. It is lit up all night like a wedding.”

The man from Logar laughed from his cot. “They are sending you to hell, Nasim. At least it will be warm.”

Las Vegas is a city in a desert valley with mountains on every side, like Maidan Shahr, and that is the only way it is like Maidan Shahr. Where we had mud brick, they had glass. Where we had one tap in the courtyard that coughed, they had fountains that danced to music in front of the hotels, throwing water into the air in the middle of the desert all night, as if water were nothing.

They found me two rooms on the second floor of a long low building near a road called Boulder Highway, with carpet the color of mud and a window that looked at a parking lot. The building had a flat roof and a metal ladder up the back, with a padlock that did not lock.

I put my empty shoebox on the shelf. That was my house.

They found me a job, at night, at a casino on the Strip called the Caravanserai [ka-ra-VAN-sa-rye].

When I heard the name, I laughed, and the woman with the keys did not understand why.

Karvansara [kaar-waan-SA-raa] is our word. It is the old word, in all the languages of the road, for the inns that stood a day's walk apart along the deserts of the Silk Road: a square courtyard with a well in the middle, rooms around the edge, and a great gate that closed at sunset. My father once took me to the ruin of one outside our valley and showed me where the camels knelt. *Here, Nasim, he said, every stranger was safe for one night. That was the law of the road.*

A desert inn. A house in the desert where strangers sleep.

In America, a desert inn is a house of gambling with a fountain in front of it.

I took the job.

—

I was a porter. They gave me black trousers, a gray shirt with CARAVANSERAI stitched over the heart in gold thread, a badge with my name in English letters, N-A-S-I-M, which I learned to recognize like a face, and a gray cart with a mop and a bucket and a long stick with a claw for picking things up off the floor. From ten at night until six in the morning I cleaned the casino floor. Spilled drinks. Cigarette ends. The little paper slips the machines give out, which people drop everywhere, like leaves.

And I learned the casino the way I had learned my roof.

It is a great dark room the size of a village, with no windows and no clocks. You cannot tell whether it is day or night. It is always the same light inside, low and gold and red, like the inside of a lamp. And in the room are thousands of machines in rows, like the cots at Holloman, like graves, each one with a bright screen and a stool, and on many of the stools, all night long, a person sits and touches the screen, and the machine makes music.

The noise of it. Thousands of machines, each making its own small song, all at once, forever. At first it made my head ache. After a month I stopped hearing it. After two months I heard it again, differently.

It sounded like birds.

A great loft of birds, thousands of them, all talking in their chests at once. *Is it time? Is it time? Is it time?*

—

And in the ceiling were the eyes.

I noticed them the first night. You could not miss them, if you were a man who has spent his life looking up. Every few meters, in rows, black glass domes, like the eyes of great insects, like drops of black oil hanging upside down.

"What are those?" I asked the man who trained me, a big quiet Honduran named Esteban [es-TAY-ban], who had been a porter for nineteen years.

He looked up and smiled with half his mouth. "The eye in the sky. Cameras, in every one. They can read the time on your watch from up there. Don't steal nothing, *hermano*." *Hermano* [er-MAA-no] is Spanish for *brother*.

The eye in the sky. Everyone in the casino says it, with a little smile, the way you would speak of a strict old aunt watching from her window.

I stood under the black dome with my mop in my hands and looked up at it for a long time.

"Hey. Nasim," Esteban said. "Don't stare at it, man. They don't like it when you stare."

TWENTY • Kayla

The surveillance room at the Caravanserai is a box.

Of course it is. I went from one box to another. It's on the second floor at the end of a hallway the guests never see: dark and cold, a wall of forty screens, a desk with joysticks, the air conditioning set to meat-locker. On the inside of the door there's a sign that says WHAT YOU SEE HERE STAYS HERE. I laughed out loud the first time I saw it.

The cameras are in the ceiling, hundreds of them, hidden in black glass domes so nobody on the floor can tell which way they're pointing. Some you can swing and zoom until you can read the serial number on a hundred-dollar bill in a man's wallet. The guests call it the eye in the sky. So do we. It's the oldest name in the business.

The job is to watch. The dealers, the players, the cash cage. You learn what normal looks like, and you look for the thing that doesn't fit.

They hired me in about five minutes. The head of surveillance read *sensor operator, MQ-9, four thousand hours* on my résumé and looked at me like I was a gift from God.

I was good at it. In three months I caught two dealers skimming chips and a man who'd been switching dice at the craps tables for six weeks. I found him because he did one thing the same way every

time. He scratched his left ear before he threw. Just a habit. Like a man looking up at the sky.

The porters come on at ten. You learn them without trying. The big Honduran who hums to himself. The two sisters who work as a pair and never stop talking. They're part of normal.

I'd been there seven months when a new one started. I didn't notice him the first night, or the second. The third night I was swinging a camera along the main aisle, and the new porter pushed his cart across the edge of my frame.

And I knew him.

I never saw his face in forty-one days. I saw the top of his head from three miles up. But I saw him *walk*, hundreds of times. And there's a thing they teach you in intelligence, and it's real: you can know a person by their walk better than by their face. A face changes. A walk almost never does. The length of the step, the swing of the arms, which way you lean. It's a fingerprint you carry in your whole body.

His right shoulder was lower than his left. And his left arm didn't swing all the way, because his left arm, and I was the only one in America who knew it, had been broken in a fall from a roof into a mulberry tree and had not been set right.

I sat very still in my chair.

And then he stopped under one of the black domes, and he looked up.

Straight up into my camera. Into me.

His face was turned up.

I zoomed in. I couldn't help it. His face filled my screen, and it was the first time I'd ever seen it.

I think I expected to know it, after forty-one days, the way you know your own mother's face. I didn't. It was a stranger's face. A man in his forties, thin, with a short gray beard, deep lines around the

eyes, and a pale hook-shaped scar on his forehead. Tired eyes. The face of a man who'd been awake a long time.

He couldn't see me. He was looking at a black glass bubble in a ceiling, like a man looking at a strange bird. But his face was turned up, and I was looking down at it, and for a second and a half it felt like he'd already seen me and I was only now seeing him seeing me.

Then the big Honduran said something, and the new porter looked down and pushed his cart away.

Every employee has a file. I found his in a minute.

NAZARI, NASIM. Porter, graveyard. Start date three days ago.

Under *notes*, somebody in HR had typed: *Refugee placement. Limited English. Very polite.*

I looked at that name for a long time. Very polite.

I didn't tell anybody. Who would I tell? *Hey, that new porter, I killed his family.* He hadn't done anything. I went home at six and stood in Wyatt's doorway and counted him, and he was nine and too old for that and I did it anyway, and then I lay in the dark and didn't sleep.

And the next night, at ten, when the porters came on, I swung a camera to the employee entrance and waited for him.

I followed him every night. I want that on the record, with the rest.

In between the dealers and the drunks, I kept one camera on him, always. I learned his route. Which aisles he did first. What he ate on his break: flatbread from a plastic bag, a cucumber, tea from a thermos. That he prayed on a folded mat in the one corner of the locker room with no camera, and came out with his face calm. That at six he took the bus east, out Boulder Highway. And that every night, at around three in the morning, he stopped under the same dome, by the main aisle, and looked up at it for a few seconds before he went on.

I was building his pattern again.

I knew exactly what I was doing. I'd sit in that cold box at four in the morning watching him mop a floor under the gold lights, and I'd think: *you're doing it again, you sick fuck. You're building his day.*

And I couldn't stop.

That's the thing nobody tells you about watching. It's not the killing that gets into you. The killing is a second. The watching is a life. You watch somebody that long, they become your show. Your house. And you can't stop, because if you stop, you'll have to look at what you did instead of at him.

TWENTY-ONE • Nasim

The man came on a Tuesday morning, at the bus stop.

I remember it was Tuesday because the bus was always late on Tuesdays. I was standing on Las Vegas Boulevard at six in the morning in my gray shirt, with my thermos in a plastic bag. The sky was getting light behind the hotels, and their glass was turning the color of fire. On the curb a woman in a gold dress sat with her shoes in her hand, crying very quietly.

A man sat down beside me on the bench.

An American of perhaps fifty. Ordinary, the way a gray stone is ordinary. Gray hair, a gray jacket buttoned against the cold, brown shoes. A face you would forget while you were still looking at it.

He sat for a minute without speaking. Then he said, in Dari, in the Dari of Kabul with the soft *r*:

"Good morning, Nasim-jan. How are your birds?"

—

I did not answer for a long time. It was not fear. I had been past fear for two years. It was hearing my own country's way of speaking in a stranger's mouth, at a bus stop in Las Vegas. It was like hearing my mother's voice come out of someone else's radio.

"I have no birds," I said. It was not true. I do not know why I said it.

"I'm sorry to hear that. You were a *kaftar-baz*, weren't you? I heard you had a fine flock."

"Who are you?"

He smiled, politely, a smile that did not use the eyes. "I work for an office in Washington. It doesn't matter which. I learned my Dari in Kabul, a long time ago. I loved your country. People don't believe that, but I did."

"What do you want?"

"I don't want anything. I came to give you something."

He took a thick white envelope out of his jacket and set it on the bench between us, and pushed it toward me with two fingers. Gently. The way you push a cup of tea toward a guest.

And I was back in the cold room in the governor's compound, with the air conditioner roaring like a lion.

"I don't want your money," I said.

"It isn't money."

—

Inside was a photograph from an identity card. A white American woman in her thirties, her hair pulled back tight, no smile, eyes that looked at the camera as if it owed her something.

A name, typed. KAYLA ROURKE.

An address in the northwest of the city.

Surveillance, Caravanserai Casino, 2200-0600.

And a gray, smudged copy of a page from something longer, columns of times and capital letters, with a black bar where some words had been hidden. Near the bottom, someone had drawn a red box around one line, and beside it, in a neat small hand, in Dari, had written:

She held the light.

"It's a page from a log," the man said. "The record of everything that was seen of your house for forty-one days before the strike. Mostly she watched. She was very thorough. One of the best they had."

He read me the boxed line, in English first, the way the interpreter had read me *a tragic mistake*. Then in Dari, with his finger under the words.

Subject on roof. Looks up at aircraft at dawn, daily. Possible awareness of surveillance.

The sun came up over the hotels, and the woman in the gold dress stood and walked away barefoot, carrying her shoes.

"I was looking at my birds," I said.

"I know. Everybody knows, now. It's in the report. But she wrote that. And they read it. And after they read it, they decided."

"And the light?"

"The missile follows a light," he said. "Someone holds it on the target with their hand. When you turned on the roof to walk to the stairs, she moved the light after you, and it went off you and onto the roof over the room. Over your wife and your daughter."

I did not say anything.

"She's here," he said. "She left the Air Force. She works nights now, in the room behind the cameras at the Caravanseraï. She watches the floor all night." He paused. "She watches you mop it."

The bus came, late, because it was Tuesday. The doors opened with a sigh. I did not get on.

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because nobody else will," he said. "Because the people who decided are in offices you'll never see, and the officers who signed are retired and playing golf. But she's real. She's a woman with an address." He stood and buttoned his jacket. "I'm not telling you to do anything, Nasim-jan. I want to be very clear about that. I'm only telling you the truth. What a man does with the truth is his own business."

Then, almost as an afterthought, he set something small on top of the envelope. A flat silver key with an orange plastic tag.

"A locker at the bus station downtown," he said. "There's something in it, if you want it. If you don't, it will go away on its own in a few weeks." For the first time his eyes did something, a small thing, I

could not tell what. "I'm sorry about your family. Truly. I have a daughter too."

Everybody has a daughter, I thought. Every American I meet has a daughter.

He walked away down the Boulevard, and by the time he reached the corner I had already forgotten his face.

—

I took the next bus and sat at the back with the envelope on my knees and the key in my fist, watching the city go by. Pawn shops. Wedding chapels with little white steeples and signs that said OPEN 24 HOURS. Palm trees that do not grow here, brought in trucks and watered every day, as if the desert were not a desert.

And I thought about envelopes.

Twice in my life an American has pushed an envelope across to me with two fingers. The first time it was money, in two equal piles, with a paper that said *from kindness* and *not an admission*. It said nobody owed me anything.

The second time it was a name.

And I understood, going east on Boulder Highway with the sun in my eyes, that they were two halves of the same envelope. The first said: *nobody is responsible*. The second said: *here is somebody who is*.

And both had come to me from a man in an office I would never see, who had a daughter, and who was sorry.

TWENTY-TWO · Kayla

I should tell you I'd been talking to a reporter.

After the Kabul strike, after the seven kids and the water jugs and *no one will be punished*, I wrote to a woman at a newspaper in New York. Four in the morning, in the break room, no name on it. *There was another one. 2019. Maidan Shahr. A man who kept pigeons. I was in the box.*

She wrote back in eleven minutes. We'd been talking for months since, on an app that deletes the messages. I told her everything.

The house. The pigeons. The line from day thirty-three, word for word. I'd never forgotten it. I'd written it myself.

You're the only one who'll say it was you, she told me. Everybody else says it was the system.

—

About three weeks after the new porter started, she called me on a Thursday afternoon while I was making Wyatt a sandwich.

"Has anyone from the government contacted you?"

"No. Why?"

"Somebody called my editor. Somebody from the Pentagon, or said they were. They asked if we were working on a 2019 strike in Wardak, with a source who used to be a sensor operator." She paused. "They used your name, Kayla."

I stood in the kitchen with the knife in my hand.

"Are you all right?"

"I'm fine," I said. "I'm making a sandwich."

After she hung up, I stood at the kitchen window, and the pieces went down next to each other the way they do.

They knew I was talking.

And three weeks ago a man had walked into the Caravanserai and started mopping the floor under my cameras. A man who, out of every city in America, had been sent to mine. Out of every job in mine, sent to that one. To the one place on earth where I would sit in a box all night and watch him.

I'd thought it was the kind of joke the universe makes.

It wasn't a joke. Somebody had put him there.

I didn't know why. I want to be clear about that. I only had pieces, and I knew better than anybody alive what happens when you start fitting pieces together and stop asking what they are. But I knew one thing. Somebody was going to tell him who I was, if they hadn't already.

And I knew the other thing, the thing I'd known since the morning I ate the chicken in the light of the fridge.

I wanted him to.

The next morning, when I got home from my shift, I closed my front door behind me and put my hand on the deadbolt. It's a good deadbolt. My mother made Gary put it in the week I moved in, because a woman alone with a child in Las Vegas needs a good deadbolt.

And I took my hand away.

—

I saw him on the bench a few days later.

The bus stop across from my house has a bench under a little metal roof. One morning, when I pulled into my driveway a little after seven, there was a thin man on it in a gray shirt with something stitched in gold over the heart. Not reading. Not on his phone. A bus came and went, and he didn't get on it.

I didn't look at him. I walked to my door and went inside. Then I went to the kitchen window and looked at him through the gap in the blinds.

His right shoulder was lower than his left.

He came every morning after that, and every morning I watched him from the kitchen window with my coffee, while Wyatt ate at the counter with his headphones on.

I knew what he was doing. Of course I knew. I'd invented it.

He was learning me. When I came home. Which window was the kitchen. When the kid left for school. He was doing what I'd done to him, with no camera, no satellite, no lag. Just his eyes and a bus bench and all the time in the world. He was patient. He never looked at the house for long, only glanced, like a man checking his watch.

He'd have made a hell of a sensor operator.

—

Every morning at seven-thirty, Wyatt left for school on his bike, and I stood in the doorway in my uniform and watched him all the way down the street, until he turned the corner by the house with the cactus garden. I'd done it since first grade. My mother said it was overprotective.

That week, I did it differently. I stood in the doorway and watched my son ride away standing on his pedals, his backpack bouncing, and I knew the man on the bench was watching me watch him.

And I thought: *look. That's my son. That's my little white shape. Look at him ride.*

See what I have. See what you could take.

I don't know why I wanted him to see. Maybe so he'd know it would cost me. Maybe so he'd see I was a mother, and know that I'd understood, every second, what was in the east room. Maybe I wanted to give him a reason. Or a reason not to.

Maybe I just wanted somebody to watch me the way I'd watched him. For once. To be the one on the roof.

—

A week later, on a Friday, the reporter called again. The same man had called her editor, and this time he wasn't asking. Classified information. A former service member in violation of her obligations. A serious matter, legally.

"Kayla, I think they're trying to scare you off. Are they?"

I looked out at the empty bench.

"No," I said.

And it was true. A man from the Pentagon saying my name should have scared me to death. I had a kid. I had a mortgage. But I wasn't scared of them.

I was waiting.

That night I called in sick and sat on the couch in the dark with the blinds open a crack. The front door had been unlocked for eight days. Wyatt hadn't noticed. Kids don't notice locks.

I don't own a gun. I spent four thousand hours with my finger on a laser that brought a Hellfire down out of the sky, and I've never owned a gun. I don't like the weight.

I sat there with nothing in my hands, and I thought about how safe I'd been.

That's the thing nobody understands about the job. You're safe. Totally. Nobody's ever going to shoot at you. Nobody's ever going to come for you. You go home at six and make your kid breakfast. That was the beautiful idea at the heart of it: war without the danger. Killing without the risk. They sold it to us like mercy. *Our people come home.*

But that's not war. War is when both sides can die. The man in the balloon in the Civil War could get shot. The boy in the field could get shot. It's terrible, but it's fair in a terrible way. Everybody's under the same sky.

I was never under his sky. He was under mine for forty-one days, and he could never look back and see me, never shoot back, never come.

Until now.

At four in the morning I went to the front door and put my hand on the deadbolt and looked out at the street. The bench was empty. The sky over the mountains was just beginning to change, the way it changed over Maidan Shahr at the start of every shift. The color before light. The color that has no name.

I took my hand off the deadbolt and went back to the couch, and I thought, the way I used to think in the box, like a prayer or a curse:

White means warm. Warm means alive.

Come on, then.

Come and see.

TWENTY-THREE · Nasim

The locker was number 41.

I do not believe in signs. I am a man who fixes radios. But the tag on the key said 41, and when I found the row of gray metal lockers at the back of the bus station downtown, number 41 was at the end, at the height of my eyes, and I stood in front of it a long time before I put the key in.

Inside was a brown paper bag, folded over at the top, the kind you carry your lunch in.

I did not open it there. I did not need to. I had grown up in a country where every man has held one. I knew its weight through the paper the way I knew the weight of a pigeon.

I put it inside my shirt and took the bus home and set it on the shelf beside the empty shoebox.

—

I did not take it out for days.

I went to work every night and mopped the floor of the Caravanserai, and every night at around three I stopped under the dome by the main aisle and looked up. I looked up the same way as always. The only difference was that now I knew there was a woman behind the black glass, watching me.

Good morning, I thought, at the dome. *I am only a porter.*

And in the mornings, after my shift, I took two buses northwest across the city to the address on the paper.

It was a small house on a street of small houses all the color of sand, with yards of gray stones where there should have been grass and one small tree each, staked to the ground with wires as if it might try to escape. A white car in the driveway. A basketball hoop with a torn net. A blue child's bicycle lying on its side on the stones.

Across the street was a bus stop with a bench.

I sat on the bench.

—

I sat there every morning after that. I told myself I was waiting for the bus. Buses came and went.

I watched her white car turn into the driveway a little after seven, and watched her walk to the door, tired, with a bag over her shoulder, and go in. I watched the kitchen window light up and a shape move past it. At half past seven I watched the door open and a boy come out, nine or ten, thin, with hair that stuck up at the back and a backpack bigger than his body. He picked up the blue bicycle and rode away standing on the pedals, and she stood in the doorway in her uniform and watched him go, until he turned the corner.

Every morning. Until he turned the corner.

I knew what I was doing. I am not a fool. I was learning her day. When the kettle goes on. Where the child sleeps.

This is what she did to me, I thought. Forty-one days.

I could do forty-one days. My young birds did not need me until noon. I had nothing else to do with my mornings.

And I thought: *and when I know her day, what then?*

—

On the ninth morning, I opened the bag at my kitchen table, with the curtains closed.

It was what I knew it would be. A small black pistol, new, I think, though I know little of pistols. A box of bullets beside it, unopened. And a piece of paper folded once, with nothing written on it. I turned it over. Nothing. As if someone had meant to write something and decided the paper said enough.

I looked at the pistol for a long time. I did not touch it.

—

There is something in our law I must tell you now, because it sat at the table with me.

In the old law of our faith, when a man kills another, the family of the dead has a right. It is called *qisas* [ki-SAAS]. It means retaliation. The same for the same. A life for a life. The family may

ask for the death of the one who killed. The law gives them that right. It is not revenge, the way the Americans mean revenge. It is a kind of justice. An old one. Older than Lincoln. Older than Geneva.

But the same law gives the family a second choice. They may forgive, and accept a payment instead of a life. A price for the blood. It is called *diya* [DEE-ya]. And the Book says that to forgive, and take the *diya* instead of the life, is better. Closer to God.

And once you take the *diya*, the *qisas* is finished. You cannot have both. When you accept the money for the blood, you give up your right to the blood. That is the bargain. The money is the end.

I had taken the money.

Four thousand dollars, in two piles, in a cold room under a picture of the President. I had signed. I had bought grain with it, for my birds.

Not an admission, the paper said. *From kindness*. They said it was not *diya*. They said it was a gift, that no one owed me anything.

But I had taken it. And by the law my father knew, the law of every village in Wardak, a man who takes the money for the blood has agreed that the money is enough.

—

So I argued with myself all morning, the way two old men argue over tea.

You took the diya. The qisas is gone.

It was not diya. They said so themselves. You cannot sell a right they say you never had.

You signed.

I signed so they could close their folder. Not so I could close mine.

And who would you take the life from? The one who held the light? She did not decide. She did not sign. She was a hand at the end of a long arm. Twenty people read that line.

She wrote the line.

She wrote what she saw. You did look up. Every morning. You did.

At my birds.

She did not know they were birds.

She did not look.

Did you look at her? On the bench, this morning? Did you see anything but a woman who watches her son ride to school every morning, until he turns the corner?

I did not answer that one.

—

I folded the bag closed over the pistol without touching it, put the bag back on the shelf, and I went up to the roof.

The roof of my building is flat and covered in gravel and the big metal boxes that make the cold air. No one ever goes up there but me.

In my first weeks in the city, at a feed store on its edge where people keep horses, I had found an old American with a white beard who kept racing pigeons. He looked at me a long time when I asked, in my bad English, if he sold birds. Then he smiled and said, *You're a pigeon man*, and sold me two young pairs for almost nothing, and shook my hand. By the winter they had young of their own.

I had built them a small box on the roof from the wooden crates the vegetables come in at the grocery store. The young ones could not go far yet. They went up in little circles, uncertain, and came down again, and I whistled to them, the two notes and the question, and they were learning it.

That morning I opened the box and let them go.

The first pairs went up, and the young ones after them, over the long low buildings and the parking lots and Boulder Highway, with the mountains all around and the Strip far away to the west, shining in the sun like a row of knives. They turned together. The light caught them. They flashed white, all at once.

I stood with my head back and watched them.

There was no sound in that sky. No high thin buzzing, going around and around.

Only my birds.

And I thought: *she is asleep now. In her house the color of sand.*
With her son at school.

And I thought: *I know where she sleeps.*

And standing there on the roof in the cold with my face turned up, I did not know which of those two sentences was the one that frightened me.

INTERLUDE FOUR • 2001-2021

A Short History of Watching from Above

The Eye Gets a Hand

This is a true story. It is the story of the machine in this book: where it came from, and how it was armed. It is the last of the four. After this, there is no more history to tell. There are only two people.

The Predator was not built to kill.

In the 1990s the American military wanted a better way to watch. Satellites passed overhead and were gone. Spy planes had pilots, and pilots could be shot down and shown on television. So they built something in between: a long, thin, gray plane with no one in it, a bulge at the front for the cameras and a propeller at the back, that could circle over one place for a whole day and simply look. It flew over the wars in the Balkans. It watched. It did nothing else.

It was a balloon without a man in the basket. A pigeon that would always come home.

Then, in the desert of Nevada, someone asked a question. What if, when it saw something, it could do something about it?

On the twenty-first of February, 2001, on a test range at Nellis Air Force Base outside Las Vegas, a Predator was fitted with a Hellfire, a small fast missile made for helicopters that follows a spot of laser light. On the range below sat an old tank. The Predator fired. The missile followed the light. The tank was destroyed.

It was the first time a Predator, a machine built only to watch, had found a target and destroyed it. From that moment, the thing that watched and the thing that struck were the same machine. Lowe's balloon and Gavotti's bomb had become one. The eye in the sky had grown a hand.

That range lies in the desert north of the city, not far from the Strip. Close enough that a man on the roof of a long low building on

Boulder Highway, looking up, would have stood under the same sky.

—

Seven months later, on the eleventh of September, men flew airliners into buildings in New York and Washington and killed almost three thousand people. Within a month the United States was at war in Afghanistan, and over the city of Kandahar [kan-da-HAAR] an armed Predator fired a missile in war for the first time.

After that there was no going back. The bigger Reaper joined the Predator. They flew over Afghanistan and Iraq, Pakistan, Yemen and Somalia, more and more of them from a base in the desert at Indian Springs that was renamed Creech. The crews drove to work up Highway 95, past the prison and the gas station, and sat in boxes, and watched countries they had never seen. In 2019, the year of the house in Maidan Shahr, American aircraft released more weapons over Afghanistan than in any year since records began: more than seven thousand.

Each one was checked against the rules. Each one had a log. Each one had someone holding a light.

If the eye never has to be seen, who is it answerable to? And what does the man on the roof owe a sky that cannot look back?

When the last plane left Kabul in 2021, the war was over. The drones did not stop. They are flying now, while you read this. Somewhere, right now, someone in a cold box is watching someone else's morning.

—

A hundred and sixty years ago, a man in a basket looked down at a boy in a field, and the boy looked up, and each could see the other, and each could die.

Since then, the watcher has become perfectly safe, and the watched perfectly visible, and neither has seen the other's face.

There is a trailer in the Nevada desert where someone is eating a turkey sandwich with the crusts cut off.

There is a casino called the Caravanserai, a desert inn, a place where strangers are safe for one night, where a man in a gray shirt mops the floor under a black glass dome.

There is a small house the color of sand, with a blue bicycle on the stones and a front door that has not been locked for eight days.

There is a bench across the street.

The history is finished. There is nothing left to tell about balloons or pigeons or bombs or rules.

All that is left is two people, and a door.

V. WHITE HOT

TWENTY-FOUR • Nasim

On the forty-first morning, I counted.

I had told myself I would not. But a man who has kept a shop for twenty years counts everything, and somewhere in the weeks on that bench my mind had begun to keep a tally, the way it keeps the number of screws in a telephone. One morning. Ten. Thirty.

On the forty-first morning I said the number to myself, and I understood what I had done.

Forty-one. The same as hers.

I had watched her for exactly as long as she had watched me.

—

Weeks had gone by like that, one morning after another, and the forty-first was the coldest of the winter, the kind of cold that comes in the desert after a clear night, the way it came in Maidan Shahr when we kept the mattresses down off the roofs. The mountains to the west were sharp and blue, as if someone had wiped them with a wet cloth.

Her white car turned into the driveway at four minutes past seven.

She walked to the door. She did not look at me. She never looked at me. But I had learned, over forty-one mornings, that she knew I was there. The way you know, on a roof, that someone in the next house is watching you from behind a curtain. Something in the back of the neck.

She put her key in the door and turned it.

The door was not locked. I had known that for weeks. On one of the first mornings I saw her turn the key the wrong way, the unlocking way, and stop, and turn it back. She was pretending. Locking a door that was already open. For me, or for herself, or for her son, I did not know.

At half past seven the boy came out. He had a way of getting on the bicycle that was all his own, a little jump, as if the bicycle might run away if he did not surprise it. A green plastic dinosaur hung from a chain on his backpack, with its mouth open.

He rode away standing on his pedals, and she stood in the doorway and watched him go, all the way, until he turned the corner by the house with the cactus garden.

And then, for the first time in forty-one mornings, she did not go back inside.

She turned her head and looked straight across the street, at the bench, at me.

—

I have tried to describe that look to myself, in Dari and in my bad English, and I cannot.

It was not angry. It was not afraid. It was not sorry.

It was the look a person gives you across a room when you have both been pretending not to see each other for a long time, at a party, at a funeral, and finally one of you gets tired of pretending.

It lasted perhaps five seconds. She did not wave. She did not nod. She only looked.

Then she went inside and closed the door.

I listened, the way you listen at night for a sound you are afraid of.

I did not hear the lock.

—

I went home and sat at my kitchen table with the curtains closed, the way I had sat with the pistol, and I took out my telephone.

Months before, in the tent city, Wahid had sent me a picture. A neighbor, a woman, had photographed all the girls in Parisa's class at the school by the river, on the last day before the winter holidays, because the school had no money for a photographer. Wahid had found it and sent it across the world, and I had looked at it once, in the tent, and closed the telephone.

I looked at it now.

Parisa, in her school uniform, the black dress and the white scarf, in front of a wall painted blue. She was not smiling, because the woman had told the girls to look serious, like ladies, and Parisa was trying very hard to look like a lady. But her mouth was pulled a little

to one side, the way it went when she was trying not to laugh. You could see the gap in her teeth. In one more second she would have laughed and ruined it.

You could not see her feet. But I knew what was on them.

That afternoon a young woman with green hair at the pharmacy on the corner showed me how to print it from the machine. A small square of paper came out, warm. It was the first photograph of my daughter I had held since the strike. All the others were under the bricks in the east room.

I put it on the table next to the paper bag and the empty shoebox, and I sat there until it was time to go to work, and I did not decide anything.

I want you to know that. People like to think a man sits at a table and weighs it all, *qisas* and *diya*, the old law and the new, and comes to a decision and stands up and goes out the door to do it. It is not like that. I only sat. And the things on the table sat with me. The bag. The box. The girl in front of the blue wall, about to laugh.

—

That night I mopped the floor of the Caravanserai through the ding and the chime of the thousand machines, the great loft of birds all asking the same question.

At three in the morning I came to the dome by the main aisle, and I stopped under it, and I looked up.

And I did not say *good morning* in my heart. For the first time, under the black glass, I said something else, out loud, very quietly, in Dari, in case she was there, in case God was listening, in case no one was.

I know you are watching. I know.

Then I pushed my cart away.

I did not know that she was not there. That she had called in sick again that night, and the chair behind my camera was empty.

That she was sitting on a couch in the dark in a house the color of sand, with her door unlocked, waiting for me.

TWENTY-FIVE · Kayla

A stranger came that afternoon, a few hours after I looked at Nasim across the street.

I didn't hear him. That's the thing that still gets me. Me, with four thousand hours of listening for the smallest thing. I was in the kitchen making a grocery list, *milk, Cheerios, bananas, something hot for dinner, try*, and I turned around and there was a man standing in my living room.

He'd come in the front door. Of course he had. I'd left it unlocked.

Not for him. For the other one.

"Ms. Rourke. I'm sorry to startle you. The door was open."

He was nobody. Gray hair, gray jacket, khakis, brown shoes. The kind of face you'd forget while you were still looking at it. On a casino camera I'd have swung right past him. That's how you know they're good.

"I work for an office in Washington," he said. "Which one doesn't matter."

He stood next to the couch where my son plays his video games, with his hands folded like a man at a funeral, and looked around my house. At the Basket of Lonely Socks by the hallway. At Wyatt's second-grade school picture on the shelf, the one where he's missing both front teeth.

"Nice kid," he said.

"Get out of my house."

"In a minute. I came to help you, Kayla. Just give me a minute."

—

He laid it out like a briefing. Calm. One piece next to the last. He'd have been a hell of an intel officer. I think he was one, once.

"You've been talking to a reporter about the strike in Wardak. You've given her the content of a classified log. That's a crime. I'm not threatening you. I'm telling you a fact. We'd like it to stop."

I didn't say anything.

"The man who mops the floor at the Caravanserai. You know who he is."

I didn't have to answer. He watched my face and nodded.

"Of course you do. I read your log, all forty-one days. You knew that man better than his own mother."

"You put him there," I said.

"Resettlement is a list. Lists can be edited. Cities, agencies, employers. It's paperwork." He looked at Wyatt's picture again. "You've been looking for him since Kabul fell. I've seen your search history."

The back of my neck went cold.

"Why."

"Because you're the only one who'll say it was you," he said. "Everybody else says it was the system. You say it was a hand. A name. And a story with a name in it runs. A story about a system, nobody reads." He sighed, like a man tired of his job. "And there's him. The last living witness to the house. If your reporter finds him, and she will, it isn't a sensor operator's guilty conscience anymore. It's a widower with a broken arm and a picture of his little girl, telling the world what it looked like from the roof. That's congressional hearings. That's the whole program on the front page."

—

"So what," I said. "You brought him here so he'd kill me?"

"I brought him here because he deserved to know. I gave him the truth. What he does with it is his business."

"Did you give him a gun?"

He didn't answer. He didn't even blink.

And I stood in my kitchen with the grocery list in my hand and saw the whole shape, the way you see a picture come together when the last piece goes down.

"If he kills me," I said slowly, "I stop talking. And he goes to prison. An Afghan refugee with an unregistered gun who stalked an

American veteran for six weeks and shot her in her own house while her kid slept. Nobody listens to his story after that. He's the man who did it. Not the man it was done to."

He said nothing.

"And if he doesn't, he's still a refugee with an unregistered gun who sat outside my house for six weeks. One phone call. Stalking. Weapons. Deportation. Back to a country run by the people he ran from."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"You'd have made a very good analyst."

"Either way," I said, "both of us are gone."

"I didn't say any of that. You did. That's a picture you built, Kayla. I'd be careful with pictures. You of all people."

—

And then he told me the last thing.

He didn't have to. He had me already. I think he told me because he was tired, and he'd carried it a long time, and I was the only person in the world he could tell who'd understand what it meant.

"The facilitator's phone," he said. "The one that kept sleeping at his house. The report says a customer left it for repair. A young man, twenty-five, clean hands, very polite. He brought that phone to that shop four times in one summer with the same broken charging port. Ever wonder why a cheap phone breaks the exact same way four times in three months?"

I didn't answer.

"Because he broke it. Every time. On purpose. By then they all knew how we found them. Where the phone sleeps, the man sleeps. So the smart ones left their phones with other people. Taxi drivers. Shepherds. And this one was smart. He found the most innocent man in Maidan Shahr. A man who fixed telephones and kept pigeons and had a little girl. A man who tested the phones on his roof every morning in front of God and everybody, and who never once looked at what was inside them, because that was his rule. The first rule of a man who fixes telephones."

He let that sit.

"He parked his phone on that roof, so we'd watch the roof instead of him. And for forty-one days, we did. Then we killed the man's wife and daughter, and the young man went to the funeral and watched them go into the ground and walked away. As far as I know, he's alive. Probably has a nice office over there now."

I sat down. My legs did it. I didn't decide to.

"So it wasn't a mistake," I said.

"Oh, it was a mistake. It was ours. We got played. That's the real story, Kayla. Not *a sensor operator's hand slipped*. Not *a system failed*. The most expensive eye in the history of the world, fooled for forty-one days by a twenty-five-year-old with a cracked Samsung and a roll of tape. And nobody wants that story. Not the program. Not the people who signed. Not you. Not him." He shook his head. "You want to tell the pigeon man he got his family killed by being honest? By never reading the messages in the box? You want to put that in the newspaper?"

He went to the door. He set a white card on the counter with a phone number on it and nothing else. With his hand on the knob he stopped, the way people do in movies.

"I have a daughter," he said. "She's twenty-three. A nurse in Baltimore. Night shift, like you." He looked at the deadbolt. The good one. "Lock your door, Kayla."

And he went out.

I sat at the kitchen table for an hour. Then I opened the app that deletes the messages and called the reporter in New York. She didn't pick up.

So I recorded a message. Twenty-two minutes. I told her everything I've told you. The man in the gray jacket. The list. The gun I was sure of and couldn't prove. The young man with the clean hands, and the phone broken on purpose, and the roof. *Where the phone sleeps, the man sleeps*. I told her the pigeon man's name, and

where he worked, and where he lived, because I'd looked that up in his file months ago and never used it.

If anything happens to me, or to him, it was this. Write both our names.

Find him. Before they do. Make sure he's okay.

I didn't know if that was the right thing. I still don't. Maybe I made sure the story would outlive us both. Maybe I just put his name and his face on a front page, where the young man with the clean hands would read it in his nice office and know. Maybe I did to Nasim exactly what the man in the gray jacket said I'd do. Made him a story. A name in a box.

I sent it.

—

Then I went to the front door and put my hand on the deadbolt.

I stood there a long time, the way I'd stood there every night for weeks.

And I took my hand away.

It wasn't stupid and it wasn't brave and it wasn't a wish to die. I'm still not sure what it was. Maybe just this: the man in the gray jacket wanted me to lock it. He wanted me afraid of Nasim. He wanted both of us to be exactly what his picture said we were. The killer and the killed. The guilty and the guilty.

Fuck your picture.

I called in sick again. I made Wyatt spaghetti, which is hot, and I made myself watch it cool on his plate the whole meal, white to a little less white, and didn't look away. I helped him with his math. I put him to bed at nine and stood in his doorway and counted him. One. On his stomach. Foot out of the covers. Warm.

Then I sat on the couch in the dark, with the blinds open a crack, the door unlocked, and nothing in my hands.

And somewhere around three in the morning, for the first time in three years, without meaning to, I fell asleep.

TWENTY-SIX • Nasim

I left the Caravanserai at four in the morning, two hours early. I told Esteban I was sick. He looked at my face and said, *Go home, hermano, you look like a ghost*. I took off the gray shirt with the gold thread over the heart and put on my own shirt, my good one, the one I had worn to my wedding and to the cold room under the picture of the President.

I did not go home.

The paper bag was inside my jacket, against my stomach. I had put it there before I left the apartment. I had not decided to. My hands had done it, the way they had set out three cups.

I also had the shoebox. The one from Kabul, from the shoes Parisa never wore. Inside it, on a little grain, was the youngest of my new birds, a gray one with no collar, born in America on a roof on Boulder Highway. A bird who had never seen a mountain or a mulberry tree, who had only ever known one home: a box of vegetable crates on a hot gravel roof above a parking lot.

I want to be honest with you. I did not have a plan. I had a bag, and a box, and a photograph in my good shirt over my heart, and her pattern in my head, and the address of a house the color of sand.

That is all.

The buses do not run much at four in the morning. I took the one that runs all night as far as it went, and walked the rest, northwest, in the dark, along the wide empty roads, past the shops that never close, the ones that sell liquor and cigarettes and loans. It was cold. My breath showed white under the streetlights.

White breath.

I thought of her as I walked. Not with anger. I tried to find the anger. I had felt it at the table, with the pistol. Walking, I could not find it. I could only think of her face in the doorway, looking at me across the street for five seconds, after her son turned the corner.

Every morning she watched him go until he turned the corner, I thought.

Like I watched my birds.

—

I reached her street at a quarter past five. The streetlight over the bus stop buzzed and flickered. Her white car was in the driveway, which it should not have been on a work night. The blue bicycle lay on the stones.

I walked up the little path to the front door and put my hand on the handle, and turned it.

It was not locked.

I knew it would not be. And still, when the door swung in an inch, quietly, without sticking, my heart did a thing I cannot describe. As if I had been carrying something heavy for a long time, and someone had taken it out of my hands without warning.

I went in.

—

The house was dark and smelled of other people. Spaghetti, and a boy's shoes, and a soap that smelled of flowers that grow nowhere. The refrigerator hummed. A clock ticked.

On the couch, in the gray light from the gap in the blinds, a woman was asleep.

Her head had fallen sideways against the arm of the couch. One hand lay open in her lap, palm up, empty. She was breathing slowly and deeply, the way people breathe when they have not slept in a very long time and the body has finally taken the decision away from them.

I stood in the doorway and looked at her.

The one who held the light.

Not in a photograph. Not across a street. Three steps away. She looked younger asleep. She looked like nobody. A tired woman on a couch.

I thought: *I could.*

That is all. Not *I will*. Not *I must*. Only *I could*. The way you look over the edge of a roof and think, *I could step off*. Not a plan. Only the knowledge of a door.

She did not wake.

I watched her a long time. Then I went past her, quietly, on the soft carpet, down the little hallway.

His door was open.

Outside it, a small night-light low on the hallway wall, the kind for children who are afraid of the dark, made a yellow pool on the carpet, and in the pool sat a basket of socks, all different, none of them matching.

He was asleep on his stomach with one foot out of the covers. The blanket had rockets on it. On the shelf above the bed stood a row of small plastic dinosaurs, a trophy with a little gold boy swinging a bat, and a clock with red numbers that glowed.

There was a small wooden desk chair by the bed with a shirt thrown over the back of it. I moved the shirt and folded it, I do not know why, and set it on the desk.

And I sat down on the chair beside the bed.

I will tell you about that hour slowly, because it was slow. As slow as the fortieth day.

I sat on a small wooden chair in the dark beside a sleeping American boy, with a pistol in a paper bag inside my jacket and a pigeon in a shoebox on my knees and my daughter's photograph over my heart.

And I watched him breathe.

He breathed the way children breathe. Too fast, then too slow, then a little sigh, then fast again. Parisa breathed like that. All children do, as if they are always hurrying somewhere in their dreams and keep forgetting where.

His hair stuck up at the back. On the cheek turned toward me was a little red line from the pillow, the way there is when you sleep hard.

I thought about the old law.

Qisas. The same for the same. A life for a life. A child for a child.

I thought it. I am not going to pretend to you that I sat beside that bed like a saint. I thought it clearly, in the old words of the old law. *She took mine. Here is hers. The same for the same. That is in the Book. No one could say it is not justice.*

And the boy sighed in his sleep, and turned his head on the pillow toward me, and was quiet.

I want to tell you what I did then. It is a small thing. I did not plan it. It is the thing I think about most.

I reached out my good hand and put it, so lightly he would not feel it, on the back of his neck. Under his hair. Where it is warmest.

I used to do it to Parisa. Every night before I slept, I would put my hand on the back of her neck to feel how warm she was. To be sure. Laila laughed at me for it. *She's only sleeping, Nasim. You think she's going to stop being warm while you're asleep?*

I put my hand on the back of the American boy's neck.

He was warm.

He was so warm.

I sat like that for forty-one minutes.

I counted them on the red numbers of the clock. I did not decide to stay forty-one minutes. I only noticed, when I took my hand away, what the number was, and then I could not stop knowing it.

And in those forty-one minutes, slowly, the way light comes before morning, I understood something.

She had watched me for forty-one days, and she had never once been able to do this.

She had seen my daughter as a little white shape. She had seen her climb the tree in pink sandals from three miles up. She had counted her. She had known which room she slept in. She had watched her through the walls, through the curtain, through the blanket.

And she had never once felt how warm she was.

She could see it. She could not touch it. She was on the other side of the sky.

That is the whole thing, I thought. That is the whole war. To see everything and touch nothing.

And I thought: *I am touching it.*

I sat in the dark with my hand on her son's neck, feeling his warmth in my palm the way you feel the small fast hum of a bird's heart, and I could do anything at all. Nobody was watching. No camera. No sound in the sky. No one to give permission and no one to stop me. No twenty people reading a line. No lawyer. No commander. No paper that said *not an admission*.

Just a man, and a child, and the dark.

And I understood that for the first time since the strike, I was not being watched. And the other side of that, the side that made me take my hand away from the boy's neck and put it over my own mouth to stop the sound coming out of it, was that for the first time since the strike, I was the one holding the light.

—

At a quarter past six, the window began to go gray.

I stood. I put the chair back exactly where it had been, and the folded shirt back over it, so that nothing was different.

I looked at the boy one more time. Asleep. On his stomach. One foot out of the covers. Warm.

Alive.

I went past the basket of socks and the little yellow light, past the woman on the couch, who had not moved, her hand still open in her lap, and into the kitchen.

—

I took the pistol out of the paper bag. It was the first time I had held it. It was heavier than I had thought. Heavier than a pigeon. Cold.

I put it on her kitchen table.

I took the photograph from over my heart. Parisa in front of the blue wall, trying to look like a lady, about to laugh. I did not say anything to her. I had nothing to say that she did not already know.

I put it on the table next to the pistol.

Side by side, the way they had been on my own table all those days. The pistol and my daughter.

I left them there, for her to find.

—

I have been asked what I meant by it, the way people ask what a dream means. I will tell you the truth: I do not know. I have thought of a dozen meanings, and they are all true, and none of them is enough.

Maybe I meant: *I could have. Look. Here is what I could have done, and here is why, and I did not.*

Maybe I meant: *You have the gun now. You decide. You are good at deciding. You decided before.*

Maybe I meant: *Here is my daughter. You never saw her face. Only her shape. Look at it every morning, the way you looked at mine.*

Maybe I meant: *Here is the diya. I am giving it back.*

Maybe I meant nothing. Maybe I was only a tired man emptying his pockets.

I went out through her back door into the small yard, with the shoebox under my arm.

—

It was an American house, all on one floor, low. There was the garage, and the basketball hoop beside it, and a metal box that makes the cold air, like the ones on my own roof. I set the shoebox on the wall, and climbed onto the metal box, and from there onto the wall, and from the wall onto the roof, slowly, with my bad arm, the way an old man climbs. The way I used to climb the outside stairs in Maidan Shahr at dawn, when they were cold under my feet.

I pulled the shoebox up after me and walked across the gravel. It crunched under my good shoes.

I went to the middle of the roof. Above the hallway with the little yellow light. Above the room where the boy was sleeping.

I stood there.

The sky over the mountains to the east was the color that has no name.

TWENTY-SEVEN • Kayla

I woke up because of a sound.

I was on the couch. My neck hurt. The room was gray, striped with first light through the blinds. For one breath I didn't know what day it was, or what year, or where I was. It was the best breath I'd had in three years.

Then I knew.

The sound came again. Above me. Gravel. A small crunch, and another. Somebody walking.

On my roof.

—

I went to Wyatt's door first. I want you to know that. Before anything.

He was asleep. On his stomach. Foot out of the covers.

The chair by his desk had his shirt on the back of it. Folded. In thirds, the way nobody in my house has ever folded anything.

I stood there and looked at that shirt.

And I went to him and put my hand on the back of his neck.

He was warm.

In the kitchen the back door stood open a little, letting in the cold morning air.

And on the table, in the gray light, there was a gun.

A small black pistol, lying on its side on my kitchen table, where Wyatt eats his cereal, next to the salt shaker and a permission slip I still hadn't signed.

And next to the gun, a photograph.

I picked it up.

A little girl, eight years old, in a black dress and a white headscarf in front of a blue wall. Trying very hard to look serious. Her mouth pulled a little to one side, the way your mouth goes when you're trying not to laugh. A gap in her front teeth.

I had never seen her face.

Forty-one days, and I had never once seen her face. Only the top of her head. Only her sandals. Only her little white shape, climbing a tree, sleeping on a roof, moving from one side of a room to the other. Bending down. Standing up. Bending down. Looking for something.

I stood in my kitchen holding her face in my hand, and I understood that I had never known what she looked like, and that now I would never not know.

Above me, the gravel crunched again. Then it stopped.

I put the photograph down next to the gun, and I looked at the gun.

I'll tell you the truth, because I've told you everything else. I looked at it a long time. I thought about picking it up. And I thought about why. To protect my son? From a man who'd sat in his room all night and folded his shirt? To protect myself? From a man who'd had a

gun in my house for hours and left it on my table? To finish the picture the man in the gray jacket had drawn for both of us?

Or to do the other thing. The thing I'd thought about on the couch, on so many nights, for three years. To finish it the other way.

I looked at the gun. I looked at the photograph. I looked at the open back door.

And I went out the back door with nothing in my hands.

—

The yard was cold. The sky over the mountains was getting lighter, pink at the bottom, gold at the edge.

I looked up.

He was standing on my roof. In the middle of it. Right above my son's room. A thin man in a white shirt, his right shoulder lower than his left, holding a shoebox against his chest.

His back was to me.

His face was turned up.

He was looking at the sky.

—

And it was the first time. You understand? The first time in my life I had ever looked up at him. Every other time, I'd been looking down. From three miles. From the ceiling of a casino. From behind a kitchen blind.

Now I was standing on the ground, and he was above me, against the sky.

I could see him. Not on a screen. In the real light of the morning. The gray at the back of his head. The low right shoulder. His breath, white, going up.

He couldn't see me. He was looking at the sky.

There's a ladder in my garage. I could lean it against the wall and climb up there. I could go back to the kitchen, where the gun was. I could call the number on the white card. Or the reporter, who'd be

waking up in New York about now to a twenty-two-minute message from a woman she'd never met.

I could do anything.

Nobody was watching.

No camera. No box. No lag. No voice in a headset saying *cleared hot*. No twenty people. No log.

Just me, on the ground, in the cold, looking up.

Holding the light.

TWENTY-EIGHT • Nasim

The sky over the mountains was the color that has no name.

I stood in the middle of the roof with the shoebox against my chest. I could feel the bird inside shifting, a small scratch of claws on cardboard. Waiting.

Is it time?

Below me I had heard the back door. A step on the gravel of the yard. Someone stopping, and standing still.

I did not turn around.

I did not look down.

I know what you want me to tell you. Whether I wanted her to come up. Whether I wanted her to go back inside for the thing I had left on the table. Whether I wanted the man in the gray jacket to come with his telephone call and his papers and his prison and his airplane. Whether I wanted the boy to wake and come to the window and see me there and remember it all his life.

I will tell you the truth. I wanted my bird to come home.

That is all. The only thing I have ever wanted, on any roof, every morning of my life.

—

I opened the lid of the box.

The young bird looked up at me. Gray, no collar, born in America. He blinked in the light.

I took him out gently in my good hand and held him against my chest. I felt the hum of his heart, so fast it is not a beat. Warm.

Warm. That is all the camera ever saw of us, I think. Not our faces. Only our warmth.

He was alive.

I held him up.

And I let him go.

—

He dropped like a stone for the length of my arm.

And then the wings opened.

Clap.

He went up. Over the roof, over the yard where she was standing, over the street and the bench and the houses the color of sand. He turned alone, with no flock to turn with, and the first light from the east caught the underside of his wings, and he flashed white.

And he went up in a circle, wider and higher.

I stood with my head back and watched him.

He would go home. He would rise until he was a glitter, a grain of salt, and then turn and find the line in the air that only birds can see, and follow it east across the city, past the shops that never close, to a roof on Boulder Highway and a box made of vegetable crates above a parking lot.

A homing pigeon always goes home. It does not matter how far you take it, or what has happened, or who is standing below, or what they are holding, or what they decide.

It goes home.

And there would be no one there to whistle him down.

—

Below me, in the yard, I heard her breathe.

I heard her take one step on the gravel. And stop.

I did not look down.

The sky was very clear, washed, the way it is after a cold night. There was no sound in it. No high thin buzzing, going around and around. Only the city waking far away. A car. A dog. A small brown bird in one of the little trees on its wires, asking for the day to begin.

And very high, almost too high to see, a glitter. Turning.

I put two fingers to my mouth.

I did not whistle. Not yet.

I stood on her roof, above her sleeping son, with my face turned up to the sky, the way I have stood every morning of my life. The way she watched me stand for forty-one days from the other side of the world. The way that marked me. The way that killed them. The way that saved me.

The way that, if she was looking, she could see now, with her own eyes, from the ground.

A man on a roof at dawn with his face turned up.

Good morning, I said in my heart. To the sky. To her. To no one. To the one who was holding the light.

I am only a kaftar-baz.

I am only waiting for my bird.

END

GLOSSARY

Baba [BAA-baa] — Dari, *father*. What a child calls their father.

Caravanserai [ka-ra-VAN-sa-rye] — The Las Vegas casino in this book, where Nasim mops the floor at night and Kayla watches the cameras. It is invented, and named after the old desert inns (see Karvansara).

Chehlom [CHEH-lum] — Dari, *the fortieth*. The gathering held forty days after a death. It closes the first period of mourning.

Dari [da-REE] — The Persian language as it is spoken in Afghanistan. Nasim's language.

Diya [DEE-ya] — Arabic via Dari, *blood money*. Payment made to the family of someone killed, in place of retaliation. In the old law, a family that accepts it gives up the right to qisas.

Esteban [es-TAY-ban] — Nasim's fellow porter at the Caravanserai, a man from Honduras.

Ex gratia [eks GRAY-shee-uh] — Latin, *from kindness*. A payment given as a favor rather than because the law requires it. The US military's term for its condolence payments.

Gavotti, Giulio [JOO-lee-oh ga-VOT-tee] — The Italian pilot who dropped the first bombs from an airplane, by hand, over Libya in November 1911.

Guernica [ger-NEE-ka] — A Basque town in northern Spain, bombed from the air on market day, 26 April 1937.

Halwa [HAL-wa] — Arabic via Dari, *sweet*. A sweet of flour, butter, sugar and cardamom, made for mourning and for celebrations alike.

Helmand [hel-MAND] — A province of southern Afghanistan.

Hermano [er-MAA-no] — Spanish, *brother*. A friendly way of speaking to a man.

Holloman [HOL-o-man] — Holloman Air Force Base in New Mexico, where thousands of Afghan evacuees lived in tents in 2021.

Jan [JAAN] — Dari, *life, soul*. Added to the name of someone loved: Parisa-jan, Nasim-jan.

Kabul [KAA-bul] — The capital of Afghanistan.

Kafan [ka-FAN] — Arabic via Dari, *shroud*. The plain white cloth every Muslim is wrapped in for burial.

Kaftar-baz [kaf-TAR BAAZ] — Dari, *pigeon player*. A man who keeps pigeons and flies them from his roof. Also a gentle insult for a man who looks at the sky when he should be working.

Kaka [KAA-kaa] — Dari, *uncle*. What a child calls a father’s brother or an older man of the family.

Kandahar [kan-da-HAAR] — A city in southern Afghanistan. An armed drone fired a missile in war for the first time over Kandahar, in October 2001.

Karvansara [kaar-waan-SA-raa] — Persian, *caravan house*. A walled inn on the old trade roads, a day’s walk apart across the deserts, where every traveler was safe for one night.

Kronberg [KRON-berg] — A small German town in the hills above Frankfurt, home of the pharmacist Julius Neubronner.

Laila [lay-LAA] — Nasim’s wife, a seamstress who made up proverbs and pretended they were old.

Lieber Code [LEE-ber] — Rules of conduct for the Union Army, signed by Abraham Lincoln in April 1863 and named after the professor who wrote them.

Logar [lo-GAR] — A province of Afghanistan south of Kabul.

Maidan Shahr [mai-DAAN SHAHR] — Dari, *city of the square*. The capital of Wardak province, an hour’s drive west of Kabul. Nasim’s town.

Mullah [MUL-la] — Arabic via Dari, *master*. The man who leads the prayers at a mosque and teaches the faith.

Nasim [na-SEEM] — Persian, *breeze*. Nasim Nazari, the pigeon man. His name means the cool breeze that comes just before morning.

Nazari [na-zaa-REE] — Nasim's family name.

Neubronner, Julius [NOY-bron-er] — The German pharmacist who in 1907 applied for a patent on a small camera carried by a pigeon.

Parisa [pa-ree-SAA] — Persian, *like a fairy*. Nasim's daughter, eight years old.

Qatra qatra darya mesha [KAT-ra KAT-ra DAR-ya mee-SHA] — Dari, *drop by drop, a river is made*. An old proverb: small things, added together, become large.

Qisas [ki-SAAS] — Arabic via Dari, *retaliation*. In old Islamic law, the right of a victim's family to ask for the same harm in return: a life for a life.

Salaam alaikum [sa-LAAM a-LAY-kum] — Arabic, *peace be upon you*. The everyday greeting.

Shahnameh [SHAAH-naa-meh] — Persian, *the book of kings*. Ferdowsi's epic poem of the kings and heroes of Iran, about a thousand years old.

Simorgh [see-MORGH] — The great wise bird of the Shahnameh, who lives on a mountain top, raised the abandoned child Zal, and comes when one of her feathers is burned.

Tandoor [tan-DOOR] — Persian, *oven*. A round clay oven sunk into the ground, for baking bread.

Wahid [wa-HEED] — Nasim's cousin in Maidan Shahr.

Wardak [war-DAK] — A province of Afghanistan west of Kabul.

Zal [ZAAL] — A hero of the Shahnameh, born with white hair, abandoned on a mountain and raised by the Simorgh.

For forty-one days, a sensor operator in a metal box
in the Nevada desert watches a house in Afghanistan.
She knows the mulberry tree, the blue door that sticks,
the little girl's pink sandals.

She knows the man goes up to the roof every morning
and looks at the sky.
He fixes radios. He is waiting for his pigeons.

Three years later, in Las Vegas, a widower mops
a casino floor under a black glass dome. The woman
behind the camera knows his walk.

White means warm. Warm means alive.

